

AN EROTIC HOTPAST THRILLER LIKE NO OTHER



HARD CORE

CHEAT CODES II

PAUL GARLAND

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An Erotic Thriller Like Nothing Before

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Chapter One

A tall man stood with his back to me, looking out over the Hudson River as it caught the golden light of the setting sun. He turned as I approached, and I recognized him immediately from the video—Adam, the man who fucked my wife while I watched.

“Hello, Paul,” he said, his expression serious. “It’s been a long time.”

I kept my distance, studying his face in the fading light. He looked older than in the video—a few more lines around his eyes, his sandy blonde hair shorter and more professionally styled. His broad shoulders were outlined against the Manhattan skyline, and his posture was alert and ready. He wore expensive-looking jeans and a dark blue button-down that seemed too casual for someone so mysterious.

“Who are you?” I demanded, my hands balling into fists at my sides. “And how the hell did you hack my car?”

Adam’s eyes flickered to the street below, checking for the sedan. A gentle breeze carried the scent of the river.

“My name is Adam Turnstall,” he said, his voice measured. “I used to work for Elysium before I became a journalist. I have some... *expertise* in hacking, especially when the device is already compromised.”

“Compromised?” I asked, narrowing my eyes at him. I took a step closer, feeling the uneven surface of the abandoned tracks beneath my feet. “What do you mean?”

“Your car. It’s not secure.” Adam’s expression shifted, becoming more controlled. He glanced around the abandoned railway line, ensuring we

were alone among the wildflowers and weeds sprouting between the rusty tracks. “Before I explain, why don’t you tell me what you think you know? Tell me why you think we’re both here right now.”

“Why should I? Can you really help me?” The question came out softer than I intended.

“I might be the only person that can.” Adam nodded, his expression softening. The setting sun cast half his face in shadow. “That’s why I’m here.”

I hesitated, weighing how much to reveal. Behind Adam, the golden light reflected off the Hudson, creating a stark contrast to the abandoned industrial landscape surrounding us.

“I found files on my computer—a ‘Cheat Codes’ folder. In it were clues for me to solve. Riddles. Journal entries about a life I don’t remember living.” I swallowed hard. “About an ex-wife I never knew I had, Claire, and mentions of a company called Elysium erasing my memories through something called Fresh Start.”

A train rumbled on the active tracks somewhere nearby, the vibration travelling through the metal framework beneath us. Neither of us spoke until it passed.

“That’s more than I expected,” he admitted. “Who left this folder? Was it you—the past version of you?”

“Claire and I decided to do it together—if what’s written in there is true. However, it seems I changed my mind at some point, so Claire decided to do it on her own. She left the files for me to find one day, in the hope that I might remember.”

“That’s... impossible,” Adam frowned, gazing out over the river in thought. The last rays of sunlight caught in his hair, turning it from sandy to gold. “After the procedure, all your computers were replaced, everything was wiped, meticulously checked. There’s no way Elysium would miss something like that, no matter how well-hidden the folder was. Claire was clever, but Elysium is... well, they’re something else.”

“So... what are you saying? Someone else planted that folder on my PC?”

“That’s the only explanation I can think of right now, yes,” Adam nodded, turning back to face me fully. “But who—or why—I have no idea. There’s a lot more to the story, Paul. The Fresh Start program is experimental. It’s not even strictly legal, it hasn’t passed all its stress tests yet. You and Claire... and Harry are the test subjects. That’s why Elysium is keeping an eye on

you. It's why they installed the tracker in your car's AI. It's how they know you're trying to remember."

"Shit." I took a deep breath, the cool evening air filling my lungs. If Harry and I were test subjects—if we'd had our memories wiped as some sort of experiment—that would explain some of what was going on. "And where do you fit into all of this, Adam Turnstall?"

"I've had an interest in what's going on at Elysium for a while," Adam sighed loudly, his eyes meeting mine. "Your mother called me. She's worried about you. She knows that asking questions about Claire puts you in danger."

"They made her sign contracts," I nodded, the pieces falling into place slowly. "As part of this... experiment. I'm guessing they paid her. Me, Harry, Claire too."

"Something like that." The wind picked up, rustling through the overgrown plants around us. Adam nodded slowly, his eyes never leaving mine. "I... knew Claire. I cared about her."

The sun dipped lower, casting long shadows across the abandoned tracks. I had a thousand questions, but one burned brighter than the others. I just didn't know how to ask it.

"I know about you and Claire," I said. "She left me a copy of a video. Of you and her. And me, in a hotel room."

Adam's eyes widened at that. I expected him to grin, a smug smile, but his face stayed serious. "She went that far? Wow. Did you watch it?"

I nodded, unable to find the words to explain why.

Adam nodded, understanding plain on his face. "Now I get why you're trying to figure all of this out. How do you feel about that? Knowing what we did, the three of us?"

"I really don't know." I stared at him, holding his gaze. "It's hard to find out I was someone else once... Someone with... desires, like that."

Adam studied me for a moment, his expression softening slightly. "Look, I understand this is difficult, but I guess we need to talk about it. Claire and I worked together for a time. After I left Elysium to become a journalist at a news outlet called The Intercept. We got to know each other while there, we liked each other... then one night, after drinks, we ended up in bed. And that was the start of it. She told me about you but I liked her... I didn't want to give her up. I'm sorry if that pisses you off, but I guess you deserve to know the truth. And... well, you've seen the evidence."

“Yeah,” I nodded. “It was a shock, to say the least. Seeing myself on the video like that... Hearing my voice...”

“Claire told me you found out about her affairs, but from what she told me, after your initial anger, you were cool with it. You weren’t even just tolerating it—you were the one who suggested she take things further. That we—the three of us—take things further.” He ran a hand through his hair. “The first time was just with you watching. You told her how much it turned you on seeing her fuck someone else. Seeing her cum when she was with me.”

My throat went dry at his words, a strange heat building in my core despite my confusion.

“She said you used to ask for details,” he continued, his voice lower. “You’d make her describe exactly how it felt when I was inside her. How different I was from you. She told me sometimes you’d get so aroused hearing about it that you’d take her right there, still... you know—wet... full—from fucking me.”

I swallowed hard, ashamed at how his description affected me. The image of Claire telling me intimate details about the sex while I listened hungrily was disturbingly arousing.

“The last time we fucked,” Adam said, watching my reaction carefully, “you joined us. She was between us, taking both of us at once. You couldn’t stop watching her face as she came with me... harder than either of us had ever seen.”

My cock stirred at the vivid description, betraying me with its response to a memory I couldn’t recall.

“After that, I don’t know much. I don’t know why you and Claire split up, Paul. Me and her... It was just casual, you know? I didn’t get involved in your relationship—or why it ended.”

I cleared my throat, feeling increasingly uncomfortable. “You didn’t?”

Adam shook his head. “Only you and Claire know why you decided to split. Or you did... However, it’s not the most important thing. There’s more to what Elysium is doing.” He glanced over his shoulder at the river. “And we don’t have much time before they find us again, so we need to get your story straight. But not here.”

Adam walked a few paces to his right, moving deeper into the shadows as the last of the light began to fade. The city around us was coming alive with

artificial lights, creating a stark contrast to our hidden perch above the streets.

“I’ve completely removed their tracking protocol from your car,” he said, his voice lower now. “I overwrote the compromised AI with a clean version. They won’t be able to track you through it anymore, but that doesn’t mean they won’t find other ways.”

“So what now?” I asked, glancing back toward the stairway we’d climbed to reach this abandoned section. “Where do we go from here?”

“I know a safe place,” Adam replied, pulling out his phone and tapping something into it. “I daren’t take you there until we’d lost your tail. It’s a... friend’s place in Brooklyn. No digital footprint, no connections to me or you that Elysium could trace. We can talk freely there.”

“And then what?” I felt suddenly exhausted, everything I’d learned pressing down on me. “What’s the plan, Adam?”

He looked up from his phone, his face now partially illuminated by its pale glow. “First, we need to figure out who planted those files on your computer. It wasn’t your ex-wife, and it certainly wasn’t you. Someone wants you to remember, and we need to know why.”

“And Claire?” I couldn’t stop myself from asking. “Do you know where she is now?”

Something flickered across Adam’s face—pain, perhaps, or regret. “That’s... complicated. I’ve been looking for her too. She disappeared after the procedure. Changed her name, job, address... everything. Maybe even her appearance. She vanished off the grid.”

“So she could be anyone,” I said, the realization hitting me like a physical blow. “I could have passed her on the street and wouldn’t even know it.”

“That’s if she moved to New York, but... yes, exactly.” Adam pocketed his phone. “The thing is, you have one advantage they don’t expect you to have.”

“What’s that?”

“Me.” A hint of a smile touched his lips. “I wasn’t supposed to be part of this equation. Your mother reaching out to me wasn’t in their plan. And neither was someone leaving those breadcrumbs for you to follow.”

The distant wail of police sirens reminded us we couldn’t stay in one place too long. Adam gestured toward the stairs.

“We should go. My car’s parked a few blocks away. We’ll take the long way to Brooklyn, make sure we’re not followed. We can pick your car up

later.” His eyes met mine, serious once more. “Are you in, Paul? Once we start down this path, Elysium will do everything it can to stop us. If they find out, that is.”

I thought about Sam, about Harry, about my mother’s fear when I’d questioned her. About the life I’d been living. Everything suddenly felt like a carefully constructed lie.

“I’m in,” I said firmly. “I need to know the truth. All of it.”

Adam led me to a sleek, matte black vehicle parked nearby. As we approached, the doors slid open silently, revealing an interior that looked more like a high-tech command centre than a car.

“Welcome to my mobile office,” Adam said, gesturing for me to get in.

The moment we were seated, holographic displays flickered to life around us. A sultry female voice with a British accent greeted us, “Welcome back, Adam. New passenger detected. Initiating security scan.”

A beam of blue light swept over me. “Scan complete. Identity confirmed: Paul Lacuna.”

“This is ARIA,” Adam explained. “Advanced Reconnaissance and Intelligence Assistant. She’s a bit more sophisticated than your average car AI.”

“Quite,” ARIA responded, a hint of amusement in her voice. “Destination, Adam?”

“The Nest, please. And engage all counter-surveillance measures.”

“The Nest?” I questioned, suddenly feeling like I was in an espionage movie.

“It’s a codename for a secret address,” ARIA replied before Adam had a chance to explain. “Not a real place, of course.”

“Oh, right.” I exchanged a glance with Adam, who grinned at me and shrugged.

As we pulled away, I noticed the windows slowly tinting black to complete opacity. “Don’t worry,” he assured me. “ARIA can navigate without them.”

The car moved with uncanny smoothness, deftly weaving through the busy evening traffic. I watched in awe as the holographic displays showed our route, highlighting potential threats and alternate paths.

“So,” I began, “who exactly are we going to meet at this Nest place? Who’s your friend that you apple about?”

Adam's expression turned serious. "An old acquaintance of mine. Someone who knows more about Elysium's inner workings than anyone outside the company. She goes by 'Phoenix' these days."

"Phoenix?" I raised an eyebrow. "Another codename?"

"You'll see," he said cryptically. "Let's just say she's risen from the ashes of her own past more than once."

As we drove, Adam and I slipped into silence for a while. I had enough to ponder on but felt even more questions forming now. Who was this Phoenix? And what role did she play in unravelling the mystery of my past?

Chapter Two

Adam's black car slid to a stop outside a weathered brick building in Brooklyn. The facade was deliberately unremarkable—crumbling mortar between bricks, graffiti tags partially covering boarded-up windows, and a rusty fire escape zigzagging up the side. Nothing about it suggested it was anything other than another abandoned industrial space waiting for development.

"This is it?" I asked, eyeing the graffiti-covered door sceptically. A faded 'No Trespassing' sign hung crookedly from a single nail.

"The Nest," Adam confirmed, killing the engine. The car's quiet hum faded to silence. "Don't let appearances fool you. Phoenix is paranoid about security, and for good reason."

We approached the entrance, our footsteps echoing in the quiet street. Adam pressed his palm against what looked like a regular intercom panel, its scratched metal surface belying the technology hidden beneath. A subtle blue light scanned his hand, accompanied by a nearly imperceptible hum. The heavy door clicked and swung inward on silent, well-oiled hinges.

"I thought you said The Nest was just a codename for a residential address," I said, surprised by the high-tech security disguised as urban decay.

"ARIA said that, but yeah, it is," Adam replied, a hint of amusement in his voice. "It's Phoenix... She doesn't do anything by halves. You'll see."

The interior wasn't what I expected either. Instead of the run-down hallway the exterior suggested, we stepped into a space that felt like it

belonged in the city, not here—polished concrete floors, exposed brick walls bathed in warm, ambient lighting, and sleek, minimalist furniture. One entire wall was dedicated to tech equipment I couldn't begin to identify—holographic displays, multiple workstations, and switch panels that pulsed with multi-coloured LEDs. Data streams scrolled across various monitors, too complex and fast-moving for me to decipher.

“Hello?” Adam called out, his voice echoing slightly in the open space. “Nadia? It’s Adam. Sorry for dropping by unannounced.”

There was a clatter from another room followed by a muffled curse in an exotic language. A moment later, a woman emerged from what appeared to be a bedroom, and my breath caught in my throat.

She was striking—tall and curvy, with half her head shaved to reveal an intricate neural implant that pulsed with blue light, mimicking the rhythm of a heartbeat. The other half of her hair was dyed electric purple, falling in a dramatic sweep over one eye. Her incredibly full lips formed an ‘O’ of surprise as she saw us, kohl-rimmed blue eyes widening with recognition. She wore only a black crop top that barely contained her impressive breasts and a pair of too-tight shorts that hugged the generous curves of her hips and thighs. Circuit-pattern tattoos crawled down one arm, glowing faintly in the ultraviolet lighting.

“Adam?” she said, her Eastern European accent subtle but noticeable, adding a musical quality to his name. “What the hell? You could have called.” She made no move to cover herself more appropriately, seemingly comfortable in her partial state of undress despite unexpected visitors.

“No time,” Adam replied, his eyes darting to the windows, checking the street outside. “He was followed. I hijacked his car and we managed to lose them before coming here.”

Her expression changed instantly from annoyance to alert concern. “Followed? By who?” Her blue eyes shifted to me, studying me with sudden intensity that felt almost physical. “Ah... Is this him? Subject Two or Three?”

“Two. The one and only Paul Lacuna,” Adam confirmed.

“So you’re *him*,” she said, her voice husky as she looked me up and down with unmistakable interest despite the tension of the moment. Her eyes lingered on my face, searching for something. “I’ve heard a lot about you.”

“Nadia,” Adam said, his tone carrying a warning. “He’s here for help, not...”

“Not what?” she asked innocently, extending her hand to me. I couldn’t help but notice how her tattoos seemed to shift subtly with her movements due to their blue glow, almost like living art. “I’m Phoenix but you can call me Nadia. Nadia Kowalski, former Elysium neuroscientist. And currently your best hope for getting those memories back, if that’s why you’re here?”

As I shook her hand, feeling a strange electric tingle where our skin connected, a tall, slender woman with dark hair appeared behind Nadia, wrapping her arms around her waist and kissing her neck possessively. She was elegant in a way that contrasted sharply with Nadia’s cyberpunk aesthetic—wearing a simple black dress, her movements graceful and deliberate.

“Aren’t you going to introduce me?” she asked, eyeing me with measured curiosity, pulling Nadia away from me slightly.

“Veronica, this is Paul Lacuna. One of the Subjects. The guy Adam told us about. The one that he used to know.” Nadia leaned back into her girlfriend’s embrace, their bodies fitting together with practised ease. “Paul, this is Veronica, my girlfriend.”

So she was lesbian. I felt a slight swell of disappointment for some reason.

“Are you sure it’s safe for him to be here?” Veronica whispered, loud enough for me to hear, her eyes never leaving my face. “If what Adam said is true...”

“Adam hijacked his car, spoofed his GPS,” Nadia said, looking to Adam for confirmation. He nodded. “And I’m going to scan Paul to make sure he’s clean. No trackers, no implants beyond what we’re expecting to find.”

“Okay, cool. I should go,” Veronica said after a moment of silent communication between them. “Let you work.” She turned Nadia to face her and kissed her deeply, their bodies pressing together in a way that made me avert my eyes, not out of respect but rather from discomfort from the sudden twitch in my shorts. “Call me later, babe. Be careful.”

After Veronica left, the air in the room seemed to change, becoming charged with purpose. Nadia led us deeper into the loft, past a kitchen area with gleaming stainless steel appliances, to what appeared to be her main workspace. Holographic displays hung in the air, showing complex neural mappings that rotated slowly.

“How much has Adam told you?” Nadia asked, gesturing for me to sit in a comfortable chair near her workstation. “About Elysium, and what they’re

really doing? Has he told you about me? How I fit into all this?”

“Not much,” I replied, seeing Adam nod, telling me it was okay to talk to her. “Just that he worked there. He knew my ex-wife. Elysium wiped my memory. Something called the Fresh Start programme.”

Nadia perched on the edge of her desk, one long leg swinging casually. “I’ll fill you in properly but first I need to scan you. Make sure you’re clean as well as to locate your Hard Core chip.”

I nodded my consent. “I understand. What’s a Hard Core chip?”

“I’ll explain later. Oh,” Nadia gazed at me, looking me up and down, “And you’ll need to get completely naked for this.”

I blinked in surprise. “Excuse me?”

“Nadia,” Adam groaned, pinching the bridge of his nose. “He doesn’t need to—”

She laughed, a rich sound that filled the space. “Worth a shot. Fine, keep your clothes on... for now.” She winked at me. “Maybe another time though?”

“You have a girlfriend,” I pointed out the obvious, looking towards the door that Veronica had left through only minutes before.

“And your point is?” Nadia smiled softly. “Veronica is cool. She wouldn’t mind.”

I cleared my throat and changed the subject, wondering if she was messing with me or not.

“So, I need to know. What exactly is this Hard Core chip?” I asked as Nadia prepared her scanning equipment—a sleek, handheld device that looked more advanced than anything I’d seen on the consumer market.

“The Hard Core is Elysium’s most closely-guarded technology. It’s a memory storage device—but more than that, it’s a discrete neural interface. You have one in your head, but first, I need to make sure you’re clean of any bugs,” she instructed, beginning to move the scanner methodically over my body from head to toe. The device emitted the same blue light as her neural implant. When she reached my groin, she paused, a mischievous smile playing on her lips. She looked at the screen and raised her eyebrows. “Nice size dick... but no piercings. Shame,” she murmured before continuing.

“What?” I crossed my legs instinctively until Adam laughed from across the room.

“She’s fucking with you,” he chuckled and I relaxed, letting her continue the scan.

“Now hold still,” she instructed, moving the scanner slowly back across my torso, then up to my head. The device beeped, and a holographic image appeared above it—a 3D rendering of my brain with a tiny object highlighted at the base of my skull.

“There it is,” she said, her voice softening. “Perfectly placed near the brain stem. Not like my prototype, which is on the outside.” She touched the glowing interface on the side of her head.

I stared at the hologram, trying to process what I was seeing. “That’s inside me? Right now?”

“Yes.” Nadia set the scanner down and leaned against her workstation, crossing her long legs. The movement drew my eyes briefly to the curve of her thighs in those tight shorts. “The chip doesn’t isn’t just an interface and storage device—it creates a partition in your neural pathways. Your original memories aren’t erased; they’re sequestered behind a firewall that your conscious mind can’t access.”

Adam moved closer, examining the hologram. “So they’re still there? All his memories of Claire?”

“In theory, yes.” Nadia’s electric purple hair fell across one eye as she tilted her head. “Fresh Start was originally designed for trauma patients. Victims of crime. War veterans. People like my grandfather who fought in Iraq. That’s why I joined Elysium in the first place, I wanted to help people like him.”

She touched the shaved side of her head again where the neural implant gleamed. “I was working on a way to help PTSD sufferers temporarily partition traumatic memories so they could process them gradually, in a controlled environment. It was meant to be therapeutic, temporary. Used for good.”

“But Elysium had other ideas,” Adam added grimly.

Nadia nodded. “They saw the profit potential in permanent memory manipulation. Why help someone process trauma when you could just make them forget it entirely? They were already using some of the same technology for Skin Deep—selling other people’s experiences—but those are temporary. This is permanent—and they’re not real memories. They’re manufactured.”

“Wow, that’s incredible,” I asked, still struggling to believe there was a chip in my head containing memories of a life I couldn’t recall. “So you were working there... and then what happened?”

Nadia’s expression darkened. “I objected to the direction they were taking. I tried to stop them from rushing Fresh Start to market before proper testing. And so... they decided to make me their first test subject. Unfortunately for me, they did it without asking.”

“They erased your memories?” I asked. “Without your consent?”

“They tried.” A small, defiant smile curved her lips. “But I’d built a backdoor into the system. I’m the one who designed the Safeword protocols, after all.”

“Safeword protocols?” Claire had mentioned safe words. I felt a surge of hope suddenly flare in my chest.

“Every Fresh Start procedure has a failsafe—a unique verbal sequence that can open up the neural partition.” She tapped her temple. “When I realized what they were planning, I created my own safeword sequence and encrypted the code into the system. I left the sequence in a safe place. They thought they’d wiped me clean, but I had the key to get it all back.”

“And they didn’t like that,” Adam helped her explain. “When she started recovering memories, Elysium came after her.”

“What do you mean?” I asked, my heart beating hard in my chest. Was this the fate that awaited me? “They came after her... How?”

“They tracked me, ambushed me during the night. Erased my memory again.”

“No way.” My eyes went from Nadia to Adam and back. Elysium was even worse than I thought. Ruthless.

“By this time, I’d been in touch with Nadia. She was helping me with my investigations,” Adam explained. “We’d made plans, just in case Elysium did this. I was her ‘safe place.’ I helped her restore her memories again and then—“

“I faked my death,” Nadia smiled grimly. “It was the only way to escape them. They only leave me alone now because they think I’m dead. Adam led them to believe that the safe word protocol and the subsequent second memory wipe caused complications. It took some doing, but I finally freed myself from them.”

“You did all that,” I shook my head in disbelief, “You had to do all that—to escape them?”

“If I hadn’t, they’d have got rid of me, one way or another. They couldn’t risk me exposing what they were doing.” Nadia stood and moved closer to me, her blue eyes intense. “The Hard Core chip in your head can be deactivated, Paul. Your memories of Claire, of everything, can be recovered. But it’s not without risks. I wasn’t lying about the complications. They’re real and can be dangerous.”

“What kind of complications?”

“Neural shock. Permanent brain damage. Identity crisis.” She counted off on her fingers. “Your brain has built new pathways, new memories since the procedure. Reintegrating the old ones could be... disorienting.”

“But it’s possible?” I pressed.

Nadia nodded slowly. “It is. Your safeword sequence, do you happen to know it? That’s your key. You likely stored it somewhere.”

“Adam says they will have deleted everything, so where would it be?” I looked over at the sandy-haired man, who seemed deep in thought. “Claire left me a secret folder. Or someone did. In there, she left her safewords, but as for me... I don’t know it.”

“Well, that’s the first thing we need to do. But even if we find it, I wouldn’t recommend using it until we understand more about how they modified the procedure for you.” She leaned in closer, her scent—something electric and spicy—momentarily distracting me along with the view down her top, her full cleavage looking inviting. “Fresh Start has evolved since my time at Elysium. What they did to you is more advanced, more invasive. We need to be careful.”

“And if we can’t find my safewords?” I asked, tearing my eyes away from her breasts as she stood back again. “What then?”

“There is another method of memory restoration,” she said, her expression turning serious, “But first of all, we need to figure out why someone planted those files on your computer. It can’t be Claire. There’s no way Elysium would let that happen. She might have left the breadcrumbs, made the files, but she didn’t put them there. I’m certain of that. Someone wanted you to remember, Paul. We need to know who. And we need to know why.”

Chapter Three

My mind was racing. The implications of what Nadia and Adam were saying were staggering. Someone had deliberately placed those files on my computer, wanting me to uncover my forgotten past. I'd been hacked, not just my phone and my car, but my home PC too. It was the only way someone could have done it, but who and why?

"So what's our next move?" I asked, trying to keep my voice steady despite the anxiety churning in my gut.

Adam leaned forward, his eyes intense. "We need to create a cover story for you, something that will throw Elysium off your scent, at least temporarily."

"Exactly," Nadia agreed. "They're already suspicious, but if we can convince them that you're not remembering anything significant, it might buy us some time."

I ran a hand through my hair, feeling the weight of everything we'd discussed. "What kind of cover story could possibly explain all this? I mean, how much do they actually know?"

"Who have you spoken to?" Adam asked, frowning, his mind obviously working hard to figure a way out of this. "Harry? Do you have a girlfriend? Anyone at work? What have you searched for?"

I sat for a moment, wracking my brain, putting everything together. After a moment, I told him. I'd mentioned it to Harry. Beth knew some of it, which I regretted. And then there was Sam. No one at work knew anything, but I had searched for Elysium from there. I'd searched for 'Claire', 'Claire

Lacuna' too. Both on my home computer and at work. What else... The hotel. I'd shown the receptionist a picture of Claire and the hotel room, asked questions. And then there was my mother.

"We don't need to worry about your mother," Adam mused, once I'd finished explaining. "The hotel receptionist... she could be a problem, but only if she knows anything."

"Which she probably doesn't." Nadia's eyes lit up with an idea. "The photo he showed her could have been of anyone. Maybe Paul here is a celebrity stalker? In fact... Here's a thought. Have you heard of Krissy Saffron?"

I'd seen posters for a Krissy Saffron tour. She played in New York last week. "Yeah, Krissy Saffron. I love her, actually. She did a show at NeuroSphere Arena."

"You *love* her?" Nadia's eyes widened with excitement. "I do too! Her music is awesome! Did you manage to catch her show?"

"No," I admitted, surprised by our shared interest. "I was hoping to, but..."

"This is perfect," Adam nodded, interrupting our moment. "She played D.C. the other day, so she could still be in town. We could say you were there to see your mother, but also hoping to get Krissy's autograph. Maybe you thought she was staying at the Cerulean and that's why you were asking questions there."

The plan started to take shape in my mind. "And I could do some searches on my compromised laptop about what hotel she might be staying in. That would explain my interest, the photo I showed, and throw off anyone monitoring my activity."

"Exactly," Nadia smiled, her eyes still bright with enthusiasm for Krissy Saffron. "It's innocent enough to be believable, but also explains your unusual behaviour."

"It actually makes me sound kind of weird. Not innocent, more like some sort of obsessed stalker, but I guess it's better than the alternative." I considered this for a moment. "But what about my research into Elysium? How do we explain that?"

Adam's expression grew thoughtful. "We could tie it into the Skin Deep angle. Say you've been curious about the technology, thinking about how it might be applied to enhance concert experiences or something similar."

“That... could work,” I mused. “It would explain why I’m asking questions about Elysium and memory manipulation without raising too many red flags. Again, I can use my PC at home, do some research, add more misinformation, make it look like it’s just work research.”

Nadia nodded enthusiastically. “And if anyone asks directly, you could say you’re exploring it for work inspiration—after all, you are in the tech business. Maybe mention you’re thinking about how similar technology could be applied to hotel management systems.”

The pieces were falling into place, creating a plausible narrative that could potentially throw Elysium off my trail. But as we discussed the details, a nagging worry persisted in the back of my mind.

“What about Sam?” I asked, the image of her with the other man still fresh in my memory. “And Harry? Are they in danger because of me?”

Adam’s expression softened slightly. “Give me their addresses and we’ll keep an eye on them. For now, it’s best if you maintain normal contact. Don’t give Elysium any reason to think you’re behaving differently.”

That might be difficult, considering the position with Sam but I didn’t say anything.

“Speaking of Harry,” Nadia interjected, twirling a strand of her electric purple hair around her finger, “We need to figure out how much he remembers.”

I nodded, remembering Beth’s concern over Harry’s nightmares but I didn’t mention that yet either. It might be significant but it could also just be weird dreams, like everyone has from time to time. I found my thoughts drifting back to Sam, wondering how to behave ‘normally’ when I’d just caught her sucking another guy’s cock. She and I were finished but I’d figure it all out later. “I’ll talk to Harry, see if I can subtly probe for any buried memories.”

“Be careful,” Adam warned, his tone grave. “If Harry starts remembering too much—if he starts snooping around, giving Elysium more reasons to worry—it could complicate things.”

Nadia stood, stretching in a way that momentarily distracted me, her large, firm breasts sticking out proudly in the tight crop top she wore. Her nipples showed slightly through the thin fabric. It looked like one might be pierced. The circuit-pattern tattoos on her arm were really cool. Intricate. Even if they made her look slightly too edgy for my normal tastes.

“For now, focus on selling the Krissy Saffron story if anyone from Elysium approaches you,” she said, noticing my interest in her tattoos but not mentioning it. “And Paul? Be prepared for them to test you. They might try to trigger memories to see how you react.”

“Be wary of any strangers suddenly trying to get to know you,” Adam added. “Elysium isn’t likely to approach you directly. They’ll likely use someone close. Don’t trust anyone until we’ve got to the bottom of it.”

“And if you see the guy from the hotel—the one that followed you—let me or Adam know right away,” Nadia added,

“Got it,” I said, though my confidence felt shaky at best.

Adam reached into his bag and pulled out a sleek, shiny, new-looking laptop. “This is my spare. You’re welcome to borrow it for a while. Use it for any sensitive searches or communications. It’s clean and untraceable. But make sure to use your regular devices for the cover story searches. We want Elysium to see those.”

“Cool,” I smiled, taking it. “I hope you know how much I appreciate this.”

“I do,” Adam smiled back. “Now we should get you home. It’s late. The longer you’re missing, the more Elysium might worry.”

As we prepared to leave, Nadia caught my arm. Her touch sent an unexpected warmth through me. “Paul, remember—you’re not alone in this. We’re here to help, whatever happens. My contact details are on Adam’s laptop. Call me if you need anything. Anything at all, okay?”

I nodded, grateful for her support, even as part of me wondered how much I could truly trust these people I’d just met. Adam led me back to his high-tech car. As we settled in, he turned to me with a serious expression, reiterating what we’d gone over. “When you get home, use your compromised laptop to search for Krissy Saffron’s tour dates and some videos of her recent shows. Maybe you can look up ‘Where celebrities stay when in Washington.’ Stuff like that. Make it look natural, like you’re just a fan trying to piece together where she might have been. And don’t forget to throw in some searches about Skin Deep. Maybe look up reviews, pricing, that sort of thing. It’ll support your story about being curious about the tech for work.”

I agreed, my mind already working on how to make the searches seem organic and unrelated to my actual quest for answers. As ARIA smoothly navigated us back towards my car, I couldn’t help but feel like I was

stepping into a role, becoming a different version of myself to outsmart Elysium.

The city lights blurred past the windows, and I found myself wondering about Sam again. I'd have to face her soon, to maintain the illusion of normality. The thought filled me with a mix of dread and betrayal, but I had to see her, if only to protect her from Elysium poking around in her business. But I'd do it in my own time, when I was ready.

"Paul," Adam's voice cut through my thoughts. "Remember, from now on, assume every conversation, text, and email could be monitored. Live your cover story. Make sure you use the clean laptop for anything else. Your car AI is fine now, and so is your phone, but even so, be careful."

I nodded, the weight of my new reality settling heavily on my shoulders. As we approached my car, I steeled myself for what lay ahead. The game had changed, and the stakes were higher than I could have ever imagined. After we stopped, I stepped out, the cool night air a stark contrast to the warmth of Adam's high-tech vehicle. My own car looked suddenly outdated, almost quaint in comparison.

"Thanks," I said to Adam, my voice quiet, unsure as to who might be watching or listening now. "For everything."

He nodded, his expression grave. "Be careful, Paul. And remember, we're here if you need us. We'll talk soon, once we've got some stuff figured out."

As Adam's car glided away, I settled into my own vehicle. The familiar leather seat cradled me, but it felt different now, as if I were suddenly a stranger in my own life.

"Welcome back, Paul," a melodious voice greeted me, startling me from my thoughts. "I'm NOVA, your new AI assistant. How may I help you this evening?"

I blinked, momentarily thrown by the change. "Uh, hi, NOVA," I managed, my voice slightly hoarse. "Can you take me home, please?"

"Certainly, Paul. Calculating the optimal route now."

As the car smoothly merged into the late-night traffic, I leaned back, letting out a long breath I hadn't realised I'd been holding. The gentle hum of the engine and the muted city sounds created a cocoon of quiet, allowing my thoughts to wander.

Harry's face swam into focus in my mind's eye. I could see the worry etched in the lines around his eyes, hear the tremor in his voice when he'd

mentioned his nightmares. The name “Annmarie” echoed in my head, a puzzle piece that didn’t quite fit. My fingers drummed restlessly on the armrest as an uneasy feeling settled in my gut.

“NOVA,” I said abruptly, sitting up straighter. “Change of plans. Take me to Harry’s address instead. Do you still have all my information from the last AI?”

“I do, Paul. Not a problem. Recalculating route now.”

The car changed direction, heading towards Harry’s neighbourhood, and as we got close, the knot of anxiety in my stomach tightened. The familiar houses lined the streets, their windows dark except for the occasional flicker of a TV. What if Harry had remembered something? What if Elysium had gotten to him before I could?

NOVA’s melodious voice cut through my spiraling thoughts. “We’ve arrived at Harry Thorne’s residence, Paul.”

I muttered a distracted thanks and stepped out onto the quiet street. The cool night air hit my face as Harry’s apartment loomed before me, a five-story walkup with peeling paint and a rusty fire escape zigzagging up its side. All the windows were dark.

My finger skimmed the buzzer for a moment before pressing it. The harsh buzz echoed through the locked door. I waited, counting the seconds, then tried again. Nothing but silence.

With a sigh, I pulled out my phone. Harry’s number went straight to voicemail. I fired off a quick text: “Hey, where are you? Need to talk.” The message showed as delivered, but no reply came.

As minutes ticked by without response, the worry in my gut intensified. My eyes drifted to the corner, where the neon sign of O’Malley’s glowed like a beacon in the night. Harry and I had spent countless evenings there, nursing beers and sharing stories.

“Just one drink to calm my nerves,” I muttered, more to convince myself than anything else. My feet were already carrying me towards the bar, drawn by the promise of familiar comfort in this increasingly unfamiliar world. He might be in there, but even if he wasn’t, I could wait there, see if he returned home in the next hour or so.

The heavy wooden door creaked open, releasing a wave of familiar aromas: beer, cologne and the faint hint of cigarette smoke that seemed permanently embedded in the walls. My eyes adjusted to the dim interior of O’Malley’s, scanning the room hopefully for Harry’s familiar silhouette.

The bar was sparsely populated, a few regulars hunched over their drinks, but no sign of my friend.

I made my way to the bar, sliding onto a worn leather stool that had seen better days. “Whisky, neat,” I told the bartender, a burly man with a bushy salt-and-pepper beard who nodded in silent understanding.

The amber liquid glowed in the soft bar light as I raised it to my lips. The first sip burned a fiery path down my throat, a welcome distraction from the whirlwind of thoughts in my head. I savoured the warmth spreading through my chest, letting out a long breath.

“Paul?” A familiar voice cut through the low murmur of the bar.

I turned, surprised momentarily, pushing aside my worries. Beth stood there, her usual glamorous appearance slightly dishevelled. Her blonde hair was mussed, as if she’d been running her hands through it repeatedly, and her mascara was smudged like she’d been crying or something.

“Beth? What are you doing here?” I asked, gesturing to the empty stool beside me. “Is Harry with you?”

She slid onto it with a grace that seemed at odds with her distressed state. “Gin and tonic,” she told the bartender before turning to me. “No. I’m here alone. Harry and I... We had a fight,” she said, her voice tight with barely contained emotion. “He went for a drive. I came here to... I don’t know, clear my head, I guess.”

A sinking feeling settled in my stomach. “A fight? About what?” I asked, though I had a feeling I already knew the answer.

Beth’s eyes glistened with unshed tears as she accepted her drink from the bartender. “He... he said that woman’s name,” she said, her voice barely above a whisper. “This time while we were fucking. Annmarie. Whoever the fuck she is.”

I winced, Adam’s warning about not revealing anything flashing through my mind. But seeing Beth’s raw pain, I couldn’t help but sympathise. “I’m so sorry, Beth. That sucks. Did he... tell you who she is? It’s the same name he said in his sleep, right?”

She nodded, taking a long sip of her drink. “It is. He keeps saying he doesn’t know who Annmarie is, but...” She trailed off, shaking her head, leaving the rest unsaid. “Coming out with a random name in your dreams is one thing, but saying it while he’s balls deep in me? Nah, something’s going on, Paul.”

The silence stretched between us, filled only by the soft clink of glasses and the murmur of distant conversations. I wrestled with what to say, torn between my promise to Adam and my desire to comfort Beth. In the end, I opted for a neutral response.

“It sounds... complicated,” I said carefully. I didn’t want to remind her about the memory wipe stuff we’d discussed. “Did you two talk about it? He must have some explanation or ideas where this stuff’s coming from?”

Beth let out a bitter laugh. “Talked? He kicked me out then stormed off, Paul. Said he needed air, needed to think. Drove away, left me on the fucking street. That was hours ago. I don’t know where the fuck he is now. He’s not answering my calls.”

I nodded, taking another sip of my whisky. The warm buzz was starting to settle in, dulling the edges of my anxiety. “Listen, Beth,” I began, then hesitated. How much could I say without revealing too much? “I... I’m going through some stuff with Sam right now too. You’re not alone. In fact, what happened to me is probably worse than what happened to you and Harry... That’s why I came over. I was hoping to see Harry to talk about it.”

Beth’s eyes widened slightly. “You and Sam? What happened? Want to talk to me about it instead?”

The image of Sam with the other man flashed through my mind, sending a fresh wave of hurt and anger through me. I took a deep breath, steadying myself. “I caught her with someone else,” I said, the words tasting bitter on my tongue. “I went home to see mom and came back early. Sam obviously wasn’t expecting me because she was sucking a guy’s dick in her apartment. She tried to talk but I left. I think we’re over but... I don’t know.”

“Oh, Paul,” Beth breathed, reaching out to squeeze my hand. “Shit. I’m so sorry. That’s terrible. Who was the guy?”

I shrugged, trying to appear more nonchalant than I felt. “I don’t know, I didn’t hang around to ask. But at least I know who she is now, what she’s doing, I guess. Before I got too deep.”

Beth nodded, her expression softening with sympathy. “Haven’t you... confronted her about it?”

“Not properly,” I admitted. “She saw me, followed after me but I got in the car and drove off. Since then, I’ve been... dealing with some other things. Work stuff, you know?”

She raised an eyebrow. "Work is more important than your girlfriend cheating on you?"

I laughed, the sound surprising even me. "When you put it like that, it does sound pretty ridiculous."

Beth joined in, her laughter mixing with mine. For a moment, the weight of our respective situations seemed to lift. "Well," she said, raising her glass, "Here's to our fucked-up love lives."

I clinked my glass against hers, the familiar ritual oddly comforting. "To fucked-up love lives," I echoed.

As we drank, I couldn't help but notice how the dim bar light softened Beth's features, highlighting the curve of her neck, the fullness of her lips. I pushed the thought away, blaming it on the whisky and the emotional turmoil of the day.

"You know," Beth said, setting down her empty glass, "You're right. Maybe it's not such a bad thing. Finding out now, I mean. Before things got even more serious between you."

I nodded, considering her words. "Still hurts like hell, though."

"Of course it does," she said softly. "But you'll get through it. We both will."

As the night wore on, we ordered more drinks, our conversation flowing more freely with each round. We shared stories of our relationships, laughed at our past mistakes, and commiserated over our current predicaments. The bar slowly emptied around us, but neither of us seemed to notice or care.

It wasn't until the bartender called out last orders that I realized how late it was. "Shit," I muttered, glancing at my watch. "I have work tomorrow."

Beth giggled, the sound light and carefree in a way I hadn't heard all night. "Me too. We're going to regret this in the morning."

As we stumbled out of the bar, the late night cold hit us like a slap to the face. Beth swayed slightly, and I reached out to steady her, my hand on her waist. She looked up at me, her eyes wide and dark in the streetlight.

"I don't want to go home," she said softly. "Not to an empty apartment. Nothing but my own thoughts."

"Do you think he's home?" I sighed, feeling exactly the same, my eyes drifting to Harry's place. The windows were all dark, so it didn't look like it.

"I don't know. Anyway, I'm too drunk to talk to him now," Beth shrugged, her breasts wobbling in her tight T-shirt. "I'd only end up saying

something I regret.”

“I get that,” I nodded, then opened my arms as she stepped into me, giving her a hug.

“It’s freezing,” she mumbled.

I could feel her shivering. I knew I should call her a cab, make sure she got home safely. But the whisky was buzzing in my veins, and the warmth of her body against mine was intoxicating in its own right.

“You could come back to my place,” I heard myself say. “Just to crash, you know. No funny business.”

Beth’s lips curved into a smile. “No funny business,” she agreed, but there was a glint in her eye that suggested otherwise.

As we made our way to my apartment, a small voice in the back of my mind whispered that this was a bad idea. But the alcohol, the emotional exhaustion, and the comfort of Beth’s presence drowned it out.

The moment my apartment door closed behind us, Beth’s lips were on mine, hungry and insistent. I kissed her back with equal fervour, all thoughts of Sam, Harry, and Elysium momentarily forgotten in the heat of the moment.

We stumbled towards the bedroom, our bodies pressed together in a desperate tangle of limbs. Beth’s fingers worked at my shirt buttons with surprising dexterity despite the alcohol in her system. I tugged her top over her head, revealing a black lace bra that contrasted beautifully with her pale skin. The sight of her—messy, wanting, needing—sent a surge of desire through me.

“Are you sure?” I whispered, my hands already at her waist.

In response, Beth pulled me into another kiss, deep and demanding. Her tongue slid against mine as her hands moved to my belt, unfastening it with purposeful tugs. My jeans fell to the floor, joining her T-shirt in the growing trail of discarded clothing marking our path to the bedroom.

I unhooked her bra with trembling fingers, revealing her full, perfect breasts tipped with rosy nipples already hardened with arousal. The dim light from the hallway cast shadows across her body, highlighting curves I always tried—and failed—not to stare at since she’d been Harry’s girlfriend. A pang of guilt shot through me, but Beth’s hands sliding into my boxers quickly banished all thoughts of Harry from my mind.

“I want you,” she breathed against my neck, her voice husky with need, her hand taking my hard cock, stroking it hard. “I’ve never forgotten the

last time we did this.”

Those words ignited something primal in me. I lifted her, her legs wrapping around my waist as I carried her the last few steps to the bed. We fell onto the mattress together, the soft sheets cool against our heated skin. Beth’s skirt and panties joined the rest of our clothing on the floor, leaving her gloriously naked beneath me.

I took my time exploring her body, trailing kisses down her throat to the valley between her tits. She arched beneath me as I took one pink nipple into my mouth, circling it with my tongue before gently biting down. Her gasp of pleasure encouraged me, and I lavished attention on both breasts until she was writhing beneath me.

“Paul,” she moaned, her fingers tangling in my hair. “Please, don’t tease me. I’m so fucking wet.”

I moved lower, kissing down her stomach, feeling the muscles tense beneath my lips. Her thighs parted willingly as I settled between them, my breath hot against her most intimate place. Her pussy was shaved, her mound soft and smooth. The first stroke of my tongue over her clit drew a sharp cry from her lips. She tasted sweet and musky, intoxicating in a way that made me forget everything but the moment.

Beth’s thighs trembled as I worked her with my tongue, sliding into her, circling her clit, teasing it, pressing harder. Her hands gripped the sheets, knuckles white with tension as I slid one finger inside her, then another. She wasn’t lying about being wet, her pussy gripping my fingers as I curved them upward, finding the spot that made her back arch off the bed.

“Oh god,” she gasped, her hips rising to meet my mouth as I kept lapping at her swollen bud. “Right there. Don’t stop.”

I had no intention of stopping. I doubled my efforts, my tongue relentless as my fingers fucked her. Her thighs clamped around my head as she came, her body shuddering with release, my name breathless on her lips.

Before she could recover, I moved up her body, positioning myself between her thighs. The head of my cock pressed against her entrance, slick and wet. Our eyes met in the dim light, a moment of clarity amidst the passion. A part of me knew I would regret this in the morning, but the feel of her beneath me, the scent of her skin, the taste of her still on my tongue—it was too much to resist.

Beth wrapped her legs around me, pulling me forward until I slid inside her in one smooth thrust. We both gasped at the sensation, her heat

engulfing me completely. For a moment, we remained still, adjusting to the feeling of our bodies joined together. She felt so good around me, wet, hot and tight.

“Go on. Do it. Fuck me,” she whispered, her fingers digging into my shoulders. “Please, Paul.”

I began to move, slowly at first, savouring the drag of her body against mine. Beth met each thrust, her hips rising to take me deeper. Her breasts bounced with each movement, her skin flushed with pleasure. I lowered my head, capturing one nipple between my lips as I increased the pace, powering deep into her as hard as I could, letting all my frustrations out.

“Fuck, yes,” she moaned softly into my ear. “Give me your cock. God, I needed this. I just need a good fucking,”

The sound of our bodies coming together filled the room, punctuated by gasps and moans. Beth’s nails raked down my back, the slight pain adding to the pleasure. I reached between us, my thumb finding her clit, circling it in time with my thrusts.

“I’m close,” she panted, her internal muscles clenching around me. “So close. Keep going. Fuck me harder.”

I could feel my own release building, a tightening at the base of my spine. “Cum for me,” I urged, pressing harder against her clit. “Let me feel your pussy cum on my cock.”

“Fuck me hard then,” she moaned.

So I did, slamming my cock harder and faster into Harry’s girlfriend’s pussy, enjoying the sound of her whimpers, of the headboard of the bed banging against the wall.

Her second orgasm hit harder than the first, her body arching beneath me as she cried out. The rhythmic pulsing of her inner walls triggered my own release, and I drove into her one last time, spilling myself deep inside her with a guttural groan.

For a long moment, we lay tangled together, sweaty and spent. Reality hovered at the edges of my consciousness, but I pushed it away, choosing instead to lose myself in the feeling of Beth’s skin against mine, in the taste of her kisses, in the temporary escape from the chaos my life had become.

I was just starting to drift into sleep, when Beth slid from beneath me, dressing to leave, the reality of what we’d done began to sink in. She kissed me softly before she left, reminding me that we both had work tomorrow.

Then, murmuring a quiet “thank you,” she let herself out, leaving me alone in the dark.

As I lay in bed, staring at the ceiling, guilt and confusion warred in my mind. What the hell had I just done? How would I face Harry after this? And how did this complicate the already tangled web of secrets and lies I was caught in?

Sleep continued to elude me as I tossed and turned, my mind replaying the events of the day. From the revelations at Nadia’s safehouse to the unexpected encounter with Beth, everything seemed to be spinning out of control. As the first light of dawn began to creep through my windows, I finally drifted into a restless sleep, haunted by the knowledge that, starting tomorrow, it was time to wrestle my life back into order. Where to start, I didn’t know but I’d work it out. Somehow. I had to.

Chapter Four

I woke up with a splitting headache. Beth was gone, leaving only the faint scent of her perfume on my pillow and the covers creased, hanging from the side of the bed where she'd slept briefly before leaving. My phone buzzed incessantly from the nightstand, Sam's name flashing across the screen as I picked it up to see who it was.

Ignoring it—noticing that she'd already tried several times this morning, the missed call log full of her name—I stumbled to the bathroom and stared at my reflection. The man looking back seemed unfamiliar somehow—haunted eyes, stubbled jaw, and the unmistakable pallor of regret.

“What the hell have you done?” I muttered, splashing cold water on my face.

The events of last night played in my mind—meeting Beth at O'Malley's, drowning our sorrows together, and then... I winced at the memory of her body beneath mine, the passionate fuck we'd enjoyed. How we'd betrayed Harry.

A text from Sam lit up my phone. I couldn't face her yet. I didn't read it. Instead, I replied blindly, a brief message:

Sam, you cheated on me. It's over. Please don't contact me again.

Harsh, but necessary, for now. I couldn't deal with her explanations or excuses, not after what I'd seen with my own eyes. I'd get back in touch with her later when it was convenient. My immediate focus needed to be elsewhere—on Harry, who wasn't answering his phone last night and on

everything Adam and Nadia had revealed. The Hard Core chip in my brain. Elysium. Claire. The memories they'd stolen from me.

I showered quickly and dressed for work, my thoughts racing. I needed to follow Adam's instructions—plant misinformation, maintain normality, wait for their next contact. But first, I needed to check on Harry.

I called him again as I headed out the door. Straight to voicemail.

"Harry, it's me. Call me as soon as you get this. It's important. I'd like to speak to you before I see you in the office."

Outside, the city greeted me with its usual morning rush—people hurrying to work, food carts setting up, the distant wail of sirens. NOVA greeted me with her overly-happy and optimistic voice as I slid into the driver's seat.

"Good morning, Paul. Where would you like to go today?"

"Work. The TechSphere offices, please."

"I know where you work, Paul. Fasten your seatbelt. Let's go."

As NOVA navigated through traffic, I sent a quick text to Beth:

Have you heard from Harry?

Her response came almost immediately:

No. I'm worried. He hasn't responded since our fight.

I hesitated before typing:

About last night... we need to talk. But not over text.

She replied, knowing what I was going to say.

Agreed. We fucked up, didn't we? Harry can never know.

The office was already buzzing when I arrived, developers hunched over keyboards, the familiar smell of expensive coffee permeating the air. I scanned the open workspace for Harry's familiar silhouette, but his desk sat empty, his ergonomic chair pushed neatly under the glass surface.

Rachel intercepted me before I could reach my own workspace, her red hair perfectly styled as always, wearing a form-fitting grey dress that showed off her curves.

"Morning, stranger," she said, her voice carrying a hint of flirtation. She leaned against my desk, her perfume wafting over me. "How was your weekend?" she asked, a playful glint in her eye. "Did you do anything exciting?"

"Not really," I said with a casual shrug. "Visited my mom in D.C. You know how those visits go—lots of food, catching up on neighbourhood

gossip. Oh, and I stayed at a Cerulean Hotel while I was there—pretty impressive.”

“Really?” Rachel’s interest seemed to perk up slightly. “On your own, or did you take your girlfriend?”

“Alone,” I replied, remembering to plant the misinformation Adam had suggested. “It was for research purposes, seeing as we’ve done the deal with them.”

Rachel nodded, twirling a strand of her red hair around her finger. She giggled, teasing me. “If I’d known... You could have invited me for company.”

“Yeah,” I chuckled, then shook my head. “Anyway, nothing too exciting otherwise—just had a few drinks last night, got some rest.” I kept my tone deliberately mundane, as if my weekend had been entirely uneventful. “What about you?”

Before she could respond, my phone buzzed insistently. Sam’s name flashed on the screen again. I silenced it, feeling a twinge of guilt.

“Trouble in paradise?” Rachel asked, her tone sympathetic but curious.

“We had a... disagreement.” I didn’t want to tell her too much. “I’m not ready to talk to her yet. Besides, I’m at work. I’ve got a lot to get done today.”

“Indeed.” Rachel agreed. “Which brings me to the reason I came to get you. There’s a meeting you’re needed in.”

She pointed with a slender finger, drawing my attention to the main conference room. Through the glass walls, I could see people gathering—Victoria Nash’s ash-blond hair impossible to miss, along with the big boss of our company, Derek Holloway, and Marcus. James Wilson, the head of Cerulean and his security advisor were there too, but there was an unfamiliar figure that caught my eye: a striking older woman with silver-streaked dark hair.

Rachel followed my gaze. “Yes, your eyes aren’t deceiving you. Eleanor Gass herself is here to check on our progress with the Cerulean project.”

“Eleanor Gass?” The name meant nothing to me, but something about the woman’s profile seemed vaguely familiar.

“The one and only,” Rachel confirmed, her voice taking on an almost reverential tone. “CEO and founder of Elysium Technologies. She rarely makes appearances unless something huge is going down, so this is a big deal.”

I felt dizzy and it was nothing to do with the hangover I was still suffering from. Elysium. Why the fuck was their CEO here? It couldn't be a coincidence. And they wanted me in the meeting.

As if on cue, the conference room door opened, and the tall, ungainly Derek stepped out, scanning the office until his gaze landed on me.

"Paul!" he called, waving me over. "Just the man we need. Can you join us?"

I glanced at Rachel, who gave me an encouraging nod. "Go on, superstar. Show them what you've got."

As I approached the conference room, my phone buzzed again with another text from Sam. I silenced it without looking, determined to maintain my focus during what was clearly an important meeting.

The energy in the room shifted as I entered, all eyes turning to me. Victoria Nash offered a cool smile, while Marcus looked like he might throw up from nervousness. James Wilson, CEO of Cerulean Hotels, extended his hand in greeting.

"Paul, good to see you again," he said warmly. "I'm delighted with your progress on the management system. Congratulations on securing the contract. I'm looking forward to seeing it implemented in our hotels soon."

"Thank you, sir," I replied, shaking his hand firmly.

"Allow me to introduce Dr. Eleanor Gass," Wilson continued, gesturing toward the silver-haired woman. "CEO of Elysium Technologies and a valued partner in this venture."

Up close, there was something about Eleanor that sent another wave of déjà vu through me. Her eyes—intelligent and assessing—reminded me of someone, though I couldn't place who.

"Mr. Lacuna," she said, her voice surprisingly melodic. "I've heard excellent things about your work. Victoria speaks very highly of you."

"Thank you, Dr. Gass," I replied, trying to keep my voice steady despite the strange sense of familiarity. "It's an honour to meet you."

"And you've met Robert Hayes," Wilson added, nodding toward the security specialist. "He'll be overseeing the implementation of security protocols at all Cerulean locations."

Robert's handshake was firm to the point of being aggressive, his eyes never leaving mine as we exchanged pleasantries. Something about him set my instincts on edge—a predatory awareness in his gaze that didn't match his polite smile. This was getting more and more uncomfortable. I wanted

to get out of here as quickly as possible and update Adam and Nadia about this unexpected turn of events.

“Now then,” Derek said, clapping his hands together, “Let’s get down to business. Paul, we wanted you here because Dr. Gass has some exciting news about our hotel management system.”

Eleanor stepped forward, commanding the room’s attention effortlessly. “After reviewing the impressive work you and your team have done, we’ve decided to invest alongside Cerulean Hotel Group and Nash Ventures on your project. Not only that, but we’ve decided on an official name for the system.” She paused, her smile not quite reaching her eyes. “We’re calling it RoomRecall.”

The name hit me like a physical blow, though I couldn’t understand why. It was perfect—catchy, descriptive, exactly what a hotel management system should be called. So why did it make my skin crawl?

“So what do you think of the name, Paul?” Derek asked, leaning forward eagerly.

“RoomRecall,” I repeated, still trying to understand why it unsettled me. “It’s... perfect. Very intuitive.”

“Exactly what we thought,” James Wilson chimed in, nodding appreciatively. “It’s a name we’ve had in mind for a long time, but now that the project is almost ready for deployment, we felt it was time to commit to it.”

“I can’t wait to get to work on finalising it.” I shuffled my feet, trying to hint that I was eager to get back to my desk. “There are a few bugs we need to fix before we can release the first build.”

“Got it. You’re a busy guy. We should let you get back to it.” Wilson’s eyes looked around the room. “Where’s your partner by the way? What was his name again? Harry Thorne, was it?”

“I’m not sure,” I answered honestly. I hadn’t had a chance to ask Rachel or Marcus yet. Then I had an idea. “By the way, I was in D.C. this weekend and decided to stay at your Georgetown property. As research.”

Wilson smiled warmly but I noticed Eleanor Gass’s attention sharpen. Following Adam’s advice about spreading misinformation, I decided to lean into the cover story.

“I trust you had a good stay?” the Cerulean CEO raised an eyebrow.

“I did, actually,” I said as casually as I could manage. “Beautiful hotel. I was visiting my mother, but I was also hoping to catch sight of Krissy

Saffron after her concert. I heard she might be staying there.”

Robert’s eyebrow raised slightly. “Krissy Saffron? The punk rock singer?”

“I’m a fan,” I shrugged, feeling oddly defensive. “The concert was sold out, unfortunately.”

“I wouldn’t have you down as a punk rock enthusiast,” Eleanor commented, studying me with those penetrating eyes.

“Hey, I’m full of surprises,” I smiled thinly. Turning to James, I decided to probe a bit deeper. “By the way, I noticed some interesting hardware in my room. The—RoomRecall—sensors. I didn’t know the tech was ready. Are those being deployed already?”

The question created a momentary tension in the room. James glanced at Robert before responding.

“Ah, you’ve got a good eye,” he said smoothly. “We’re just trialling those in select rooms. Not operational yet.”

“They’re part of a guest experience enhancement initiative,” Robert explained, his voice expertly neutral. “Just gathering baseline data at this stage.”

“Fascinating,” I replied, making a mental note of their reactions. “I’d love to hear more about that technology sometime and how the emotion monitoring is going to be used through RoomRecall.”

“Of course,” James nodded, though his smile didn’t quite reach his eyes. “We’re quite excited about the possibilities. We don’t have time today but I’m sure I could get Robert to email you a summary.”

Victoria cleared her throat. “Well, I think we’ve covered the essentials for today. Paul, we’ll need a progress report on the implementation timeline by Friday.”

As the meeting began to wrap up, I noticed Marcus fidgeting with his tablet, occasionally glancing my way with an expression that suggested he was bursting to tell me something. When our eyes met, he gave me a slight nod that I interpreted as “talk to me later.”

Derek stood, signalling the end of the meeting. “Excellent work, everyone. Paul, I’m told Harry called in sick this morning. I know you’re friends, so if you see him, please pass along our best wishes. Tell him we hope he recovers quickly.”

Harry was sick? I felt unsettled. I needed to talk to him. As we filed out of the conference room, I felt Eleanor’s gaze following me, like a physical

weight between my shoulder blades. Whatever connection Elysium had to our work at TechSphere, I was certain it went far deeper than a simple business partnership.

Back at my desk, I tried to focus on work, but my mind kept circling back to the strange meeting. Something about RoomRecall and the trial sensors James had mentioned didn't sit right. Was Cerulean collecting data without guests' knowledge? And if so, how? Without RoomRecall operational, what were they really doing? And why was Elysium's CEO personally interested and investing in a hotel management system?

I was deep in the RoomRecall code when a shadow fell across my screen. Marcus stood there, his usual nervous energy amplified. He glanced around furtively before leaning down.

"Got a minute?" he whispered, his voice barely audible over the office ambient noise.

"Sure." I glanced around. "Is everything okay? What's up?"

Marcus fidgeted with the lanyard around his neck. "I think I figured something out about that bug we've been hunting. The one in the transfer protocol."

"Oh?" I sat up straighter. "I thought I'd fixed that last week. The memory allocation issue in the data processing module."

Marcus's face tightened. "It's back. But it's not... I don't think it's a bug, Paul."

Something in his tone sent a chill down my spine. "What do you mean?"

He leaned closer, opening his mouth to continue when Rachel appeared beside us, two coffee cups in hand.

"Thought you could use this," she said, placing one on my desk. "You looked stressed during the meeting."

Marcus straightened abruptly, his expression closing. "We'll talk later," he muttered. "I've got some... tests to run. But it's important."

As he hurried back to his desk, Rachel watched him with curious eyes. "What's got him so worked up? More than usual, I mean."

I shrugged, accepting the coffee. "Technical stuff. That bug is driving us crazy."

"Ah, the infamous bug." Rachel perched on the edge of my desk, her skirt riding up slightly, showing a sexy amount of pale thigh. "So, about that drink? My offer still stands. Maybe you could use someone to talk to about the disagreement with your girlfriend."

The invitation was tempting. Rachel was attractive and easy to talk to, and after everything with Sam, a simple, uncomplicated evening had its appeal. But Harry's absence and updating Adam on Elysium's sudden involvement in my work were more important.

"Rain check?" I said, offering an apologetic smile. "I need to check on Harry, and I... well, I should probably hear Sam out before I completely write her off."

Something flickered across Rachel's face—disappointment? Or something else?—before she nodded. "Write her off? Is it as bad as that? Wow. But, yeah... Of course. Being the bigger person and all that. Very mature." Her tone was light, but there was an edge to it. "Let me know when you're ready for that rain check."

As she walked away, I couldn't help but appreciate the view of her ass in that tight skirt. If things really were over with Sam, maybe Rachel would be worth exploring. Something about her had always intrigued me, though I'd never seriously considered it before.

My phone buzzed with another text from Sam. I flicked through them, before replying to the last one which read: *Please. Just one drink. I can explain everything. O'Malley's at 7?*

After a moment's hesitation, I typed: *Fine. One drink. But don't think you can talk me around, Sam. I owe you a chance to explain, that's all it is.*

Adam had told me to try to maintain my friendships as normal if I wanted to protect everyone. I didn't know how I could do that considering what had happened but I hit send.

The rest of the afternoon dragged by, my concentration shot. I tried calling Harry twice more, both attempts going straight to voicemail. By six, I'd had enough.

"NOVA," I instructed my car as I slid into the driver's seat, "take me to Harry Thorne's address."

The drive to Harry's Brooklyn apartment took longer than usual, rush hour traffic clogging the streets. When I finally arrived, the old brownstone looked quiet, no lights visible in Harry's third-floor windows. I buzzed his apartment repeatedly, but there was no answer.

A neighbour exiting the building held the door for me, and I made my way up the worn stairs to Harry's floor. Standing outside his apartment, I knocked loudly.

"Harry! It's Paul. Are you there?"

Silence greeted me. I tried the doorknob—locked, of course. Pressing my ear to the door, I couldn't detect any movement inside. After a final, futile knock, I reluctantly headed back downstairs.

It was nearly seven when I reached O'Malley's, the bar already filling with the after-work crowd. The familiar smells of beer and cologne greeted me as I pushed through the door, scanning the dimly lit interior for Sam.

She sat at a small table in the corner, her brunette hair pulled back in a simple ponytail, wearing the blue blouse I'd once told her matched her eyes. When she spotted me, a mixture of relief and apprehension crossed her face.

"Thank you for coming," she said as I slid into the chair across from her. "I wasn't sure you would."

"Neither was I," I admitted, signalling to the bartender for a whisky. "You have five minutes, Sam. Make it good."

She took a deep breath, her fingers nervously twisting a cocktail napkin. "What you saw... it wasn't what you think."

"I saw you in your apartment," I said flatly. "With another man's cock in your mouth. What exactly am I misunderstanding?"

Sam's eyes met mine, steady and serious. "The man you saw is my ex, Paul. His name is Raoul. We broke up months ago, before I met you."

I blinked, trying to process this. "Your ex? Then why the hell was he there? Why were you...?" I couldn't even finish the sentence.

"He's been trying to win me back," she said softly, her fingers nervously twisting the cocktail napkin. "I told him last week it was over for good because I was committing to you. That's when he showed up yesterday, saying if I gave him one last time together, he'd leave me alone forever."

The bartender arrived with my whiskey, giving me a moment to absorb her words. I took a large swallow, welcoming the burn.

"So you agreed to suck him off as a goodbye present?" I couldn't keep the bitterness from my voice.

Sam winced. "It sounds terrible when you put it like that. I thought it would be the cleanest break - give him what he wanted and be done with it forever. I know it was wrong, but I didn't expect you to show up."

"That doesn't make it better, Sam."

"I know," she whispered, a tear sliding down her cheek. "I made a horrible mistake. I care about you, Paul. More than I expected to."

I stared at her, conflicted. "Did you go through with it? After I left?"

She opened her mouth to answer, but before she could speak, my phone rang. Marcus's name flashed on the screen. Why was he calling me now? Marcus never rang outside of work hours.

"I should take this," I said, holding up a finger. "Work."

Stepping away from the table, I answered. "Marcus? What's up?"

His voice came through in a rushed whisper. "Paul, I need to show you something. About RoomRecall."

"To do with the bug?" I asked. "I'm busy right now. Can it wait until tomorrow?"

"It's not a bug, Paul." Marcus's voice quietened, almost a whisper. "It's a back door. Listen, this sounds crazy but I think we're being used to—"

The call abruptly cut off, leaving me staring at my phone in confusion. When I tried calling back, it went straight to voicemail.

I returned to the table, my unease growing by the minute. "Sorry about that," I said to Sam, though my mind was now racing with new concerns. "Work emergency."

Sam studied my face. "Is everything okay? You look worried."

"Fine," I lied, downing the rest of my whisky. Meeting Sam tonight had been a mistake. I'd only been here a short time but even that was too long. I needed to check in with Harry, tell him what Marcus had just said. He might understand. I grabbed my jacket. "But I do have to go. Something's come up that I need to work on before tomorrow."

Sam's eyes widened with panic. "Paul, wait. Please don't leave like this. Don't end things." She reached for my hand, her touch sending an unexpected jolt through me. "Give me a chance to make it up to you."

At her touch, an unbidden image flashed in my mind—Sam on her knees, her lips wrapped around Raoul's cock. The mental picture was vivid and startlingly detailed. I could see the way her dark hair fell across her face, how her hazel eyes looked up at him with a mix of desire and submission. Raoul's hands tangled in her hair, guiding her movements as she took him deeper, all the way to his balls.

To my surprise, instead of disgust, I felt a surge of arousal course through me. My body reacted instinctively, blood rushing south as I imagined Sam's lips stretched wide, her cheeks hollowed as she sucked. I could almost hear the soft, wet sounds, picture the way her throat would work as she swallowed around him.

Then my mind went further, showing me what might have happened after I left. Sam rising from her knees, pushing Raoul back onto her couch, climbing atop him. Her perfect breasts bouncing as she rode him, the same way she'd ridden me just nights before. Her head thrown back in pleasure, moaning his name the way she'd moaned mine. The image of her pussy—the one I'd tasted, the one I'd been inside—now taking another man's cock, gripping him tight, her wetness coating him.

I pushed the thought away forcefully, confused and a little disturbed by my own reaction. What was wrong with me? This was Sam—my Sam—with another man. I should be furious, jealous, heartbroken. Instead, I found myself aroused. Was this how I was before, with Claire and Adam?

"Sam, I..." I hesitated, torn between the urgency of Marcus's call and my need to find Harry, and the plea in Sam's eyes. "I can't deal with this right now. There's too much going on. I came to give you a chance to explain, to apologise and you've done that, so..."

"Tomorrow night then," she said quickly. "Let's finish this tomorrow, when you have more time. I promise I'll be worth it if you just forgive me."

I watched as a single tear ran down her cheek. I couldn't just deny her, not like this. I sighed, running a hand through my hair. "Fine. Tomorrow night. But I can't promise anything. You cheated and..." I hesitated. I'd fucked Beth last night. "You cheated and that's it."

Sam nodded eagerly. "Let's just talk tomorrow. That's all I ask. Thank you, Paul."

As I left O'Malley's, my mind was a whirlwind of conflicting thoughts and emotions. The image of Sam with Raoul kept intruding, mixing uncomfortably with my worry for Marcus and Harry. I needed to find Harry, to work out what the hell was going on. Adam and Nadia needed to know everything. Whatever Marcus had discovered about RoomRecall, I had a feeling it was just the tip of the iceberg.

Chapter Five

The elevator doors opened with a soft ping, and I stepped into the hallway outside my apartment, my mind still racing from the events of the day. Harry was still nowhere to be found, his phone going straight to voicemail and his apartment silent when I checked it for the second time. Marcus's phone was also switched off, so I'd headed home without any answers.

My key chip unlocked the door with a quiet click. I immediately noticed that the apartment was spotless. Haley had been here. The lingering scent of lavender cleaner hung in the air, and everything was meticulously organised. Even my desk, usually a chaotic mess of papers and tech, had been rearranged with her usual tidyness.

In the bedroom, I found a neat stack of laundry on the bed — freshly washed and folded. My eyes widened when I spotted Beth's black lace bra sitting innocently atop the pile. I winced at the carefully folded state of the garment, Haley had cleaned and placed it here. I made a mental note to increase her pay next time I saw her.

Feeling like I was being paranoid, I scouted the house, checking everywhere I could think of for microphones or hidden cameras. Adam's warnings about my laptop and car being compromised had me on edge, but I couldn't find anything out of the ordinary. After verifying I was okay to do so, I pulled Adam's laptop from my bag — the sleek device that he'd assured me was safe to use and settled at my kitchen table. On the desktop were two communication icons, one labelled for him, the other for Nadia. I selected Adam and waited. The screen remained blank for several seconds

before his face appeared, his features bathed in the blue glow of whatever screen he was looking at.

“Paul,” he greeted me, his expression immediately alert. “What’s up?”

“Where do I fucking start? I guess the biggest thing is that Elysium showed up at our office today,” I said without preamble. “The goddamn CEO. A woman called Eleanor Gass. Do you know her?”

“No way.” Adam’s eyes widened as I nodded. “That’s insane. Eleanor Gass rarely leaves their Elysium HQ. Why was she there?”

“I work at a company called TechSphere. I moved there from D.C. when it was just a start-up, and we’ve put out a few applications, but the one we’re working on now — a hotel management system— they’ve heavily invested in it for some reason. Our boss called us into a meeting to announce the name they’ve decided on: “RoomRecall.” Gass was there with Victoria Nash, one of TechSphere’s big investors, and the CEO and security specialist from Cerulean Hotels. But Elysium being there... it can’t be a coincidence.”

Adam’s jaw tightened. “Definitely not. They’re keeping tabs on you and Harry. What was their interest in the system? What does it do?”

“It’s multi-faceted, hotel management software. It manages things like ambient sound, room temperature and lighting, but the unique part of it is that it connects via sensors in the hotel rooms to the user for a bespoke and tailored experience.”

“Sensors? What kind of sensors?”

“Primarily environmental monitoring. Temperature, lighting, occupancy, and sound. But it also connects to the users movements, listens to their voice modulations, monitors their behaviour and tries to recognise and connect their emotions to produce the best experience for the user, while recording data that the hotel can use to improve their rooms and product in the future for that user on their next stay.”

Adam’s expression darkened. “This is significant, Paul. If Elysium is involved, it’s more than that. Trust me, if they’re embedding monitoring technology in hotels...” He paused, typing something off-screen. “Listen, Nadia needs to hear this. She’s been analyzing what we know about the chip in your head.”

The screen split, and Nadia appeared, her purple hair and neural implants as striking as when I’d met her in The Nest.

“Hello, cutie,” she greeted me with a flirty smile and a nod before her expression turned more intense. “Adam says you’ve got new information.”

I quickly recounted the meeting, watching Nadia’s eyes narrow as I described Eleanor Gass’s interest in RoomRecall, the sensors and also the bug Marcus had been tracking.

“He said it’s more than a bug,” I explained. “But before he could tell me anything else, the line cut off, and now I can’t get hold of him. I’ll have to wait until tomorrow to talk to him at work, but if I learn anything more, I’ll keep you updated.”

“I’m going to look into it,” she replied. “Now, about the Hard Core chip, Adam and I have managed to unlock some of the files on Elysium’s website but as you can imagine, the main product details are behind firewalls and encrypted.”

“Okay. So what have you learned so far?” I asked, suddenly aware again of the tiny device embedded at the base of my skull, hidden where I couldn’t see or feel it.

“The chip doesn’t just block memories, Paul,” she explained, picking up where our previous conversation had left off. “It also induces a form of targeted prosopagnosia — face blindness — for specific individuals. Even if you encountered Claire today, the chip would alter your perception of her facial features. You could be looking right at her and not recognize her.”

I felt my stomach knot. “So I could have seen her? Talked to her?”

“It’s possible,” Nadia said, her eyes flickering to Adam before returning to me. Her gaze was intense, almost flirtatious, as she leaned closer to her camera. “The good news is, as we discussed, I think we might be able to deactivate it remotely, but it’s risky. Your safe word sequence would be safer — it’s designed to gradually restore your memories without neural trauma.”

“Have you had any thoughts or ideas about what your sequence might be?” Adam asked.

“I haven’t had time to think about it,” I admitted, then remembered the other reason for my call. “There’s something else. Harry’s missing.”

Adam’s head snapped up. “What do you mean, missing?”

“He called in sick today, according to my boss. But I went by his place twice, and there’s no sign of him. His phone goes straight to voicemail. His girlfriend, Beth,” I swallowed, my mouth going dry at the sound of her name, “She hasn’t heard from him since they argued yesterday.”

“What was the argument about?” Nadia asked sharply.

“He mentioned a woman’s name in his sleep a while ago, said it a couple of times. Then yesterday, he said it again while they were... ah, in bed, shall we say?”

“What name?” Adam asked, his eyes fixed on mine through the camera.

“Annmarie,” I told him. “Beth confronted him about it, and he got defensive. Then he just... disappeared.”

Adam and Nadia exchanged a meaningful look.

“I don’t know everything about Harry, but I know that Annmarie was his partner before the memory wipe,” Adam said quietly. “If he’s experiencing nocturnal vocalizations of her name...”

“His Hard Core chip could be exhibiting signs of synaptic reversion,” Nadia finished, twirling a strand of purple hair around her finger. “You need to prioritise decoding your safe word sequence, handsome. Because if those chips start undergoing full cognitive desynchronization...” She drew a finger across her throat.

“Let’s not be alarmist,” Adam frowned, shaking his head. “There could be side-effects, possibly some damage to mnemonic integrity, but it’s not life-threatening.”

“Side effects?” I asked, my heart suddenly thumping in my chest. “I’ve been having... I don’t know what you’d call them. Weird feelings of people being familiar... And I had a particularly vivid flashback that wasn’t a flashback. I don’t know how to describe it.”

I was referring to the vision of Sam with Raoul, but I wasn’t prepared to divulge the details of my unfaithful girlfriend at this juncture.

“Those sound like classic symptoms of temporal echo syndrome,” Nadia nodded gravely. “Memory hallucinations. We need to identify your safe word sequence as soon as possible to prevent it from getting worse.”

“And we need to find Harry,” Adam added, his concern evident. “If he’s remembering Annmarie, Elysium might already know. They could have taken him in for... maintenance.”

The thought sent a chill down my spine. My best friend, in the hands of people who had already stolen our memories once.

“I’ll keep looking,” I promised. “And I’ll work on the safe word sequence.”

“Good,” Nadia said, her lips curving into a flirtatious smile. “Because I’d hate to lose that pretty face of yours to neural degeneration. The Hard Core

chip wasn't designed to fail gracefully."

"I appreciate your concern," I said, feeling a mix of flattery and unease at Nadia's flirtation. "But you're not doing much to put my mind at rest here."

Nadia leaned closer to her camera, her purple hair falling to one side. "Well, handsome, would you rather know the truth or have us tell you what you want to hear? Look, the Hard Core chip is incredibly complex. If it degrades, you might experience more than just memory bleed-through. Hallucinations, sensory glitches, and even personality shifts are possible. That's why finding your safe word sequence is crucial."

"She's right, Paul," Adam interjected, his tone serious. "Time might not be on our side. But it might be fine. The Hard Core chips might not be failing. It could merely be that the reminders you've been left have jogged something, jarred some of those old memories loose. Either way, keep digging, trying to find your safe word sequence. And be careful. Elysium could have eyes anywhere."

I nodded, feeling the weight of their warnings. "I'll do my best. Thank you both for everything."

After saying our goodbyes, I closed the secure laptop and sat back, my mind reeling. I needed to transfer the Cheat Codes folder from my potentially compromised computer to Adam's secure device. With a deep breath, I began the process, triple-checking that every file was copied successfully.

Once the transfer was complete, I permanently deleted the folder from my personal computer. "Sorry, Claire," I murmured as I watched the progress bar complete. "But I'm not taking any chances."

With the data secured, I carried Adam's laptop to my bedroom. I didn't eat. I couldn't. My hunger was gone from worrying. Sleep felt impossible, my thoughts a whirlwind of questions and anxiety. Propping myself against the headboard, I opened the laptop and navigated to the journal entries I hadn't yet explored.

There were dozens of them, each dated meticulously. Claire had been thorough in documenting both her own and our shared experiences. My mouse pointer selected a random entry, my heart pounding. Whatever I was about to read would shed light on a past I couldn't remember — a life I had chosen to forget.

Taking a deep breath, I clicked on a random entry that wasn't locked and began to read.

Journal Entry: April 15, 2029 — Jean-Marc

I ran into Jean-Marc at the gym today. God, it's been years since high school, but I recognized him instantly. He's changed so much — all grown up now, his body sculpted and defined where he used to be that lanky boy I secretly crushed on in French class.

I was on the treadmill when I spotted him lifting weights across the room and couldn't help but stare at how his muscles flexed beneath his tight shirt, the way the sweat made his bronze skin glisten. When our eyes met, that familiar flutter hit my stomach — the same one I'd felt at sixteen when he'd smile at me in the hallway.

After my workout, he approached me at the water fountain. We got to talking about old times, catching up on the years between us last seeing each other. He works in finance now, just moved back to the city after a few years in Paris. When he mentioned he was single, I felt that dangerous thrill course through me.

I didn't plan what happened next. Or maybe I did. I invited him for coffee, which turned into lunch. The whole time, I kept noticing the substantial bulge in his shorts. It was... distracting. Impossible to ignore really.

Over dinner, I found myself telling him about Paul and me — about our arrangement. About how Paul likes to watch. I've never been so forward before, but something about Jean-Marc makes me reckless. When I asked if he'd be interested, his eyes lit up, and he simply said, "When? How about now?"

I texted Paul as we finished up, told him I was bringing someone home. His response was immediate: "Can't wait to see you with him."

Jean-Marc was nervous at first when Paul greeted us, but Paul has that way of making everything seem normal. The three of us had a drink, making small talk but we all knew what was going to happen. Paul sat in his usual chair as Jean-Marc and I moved to the couch. The first kiss was electric — Jean-Marc's lips soft but commanding, his tongue exploring mine with confidence that made my knees weak and my pussy wet.

When our clothes started coming off, I noticed Paul's manner change, that familiar look of horniness in his eyes. Jean-Marc's body is magnificent — all hard planes and defined muscles where Paul is softer, more average. But it wasn't until Jean-Marc removed his boxers that I truly understood what I'd gotten myself into.

His cock is massive. There's no other way to describe it. Thick and heavy, at least nine inches and so girthy I wondered if I could wrap my hand around it. I hate myself for thinking it, but comparing it to Paul's more modest size made me realise just how average my husband really is. Not that there's anything wrong with that.

Paul watched from his chair as I took Jean-Marc into my mouth. I could barely fit the head past my lips, but God, I tried. Jean-Marc groaned, his fingers tangling in my hair as I worked him with both hands and my mouth. When I looked over at Paul, his eyes were fixed on my lips stretched around Jean-Marc's shaft, his hand moving rhythmically beneath his pants.

When Jean-Marc finally pushed me onto my back and shoved his cock inside my soaking wet pussy, the sensation was overwhelming. I felt completely filled, stretched in ways Paul has never managed. Each thrust hit places inside me that I didn't know existed, sending waves of pleasure so intense I could barely breathe. I hate to admit it, but Jean-Marc fucks better than Paul ever has — more controlled, more attentive, more... everything.

He took me in positions Paul and I never tried — lifting me against the wall, his strong arms supporting my weight as he pounded into me. On all fours, his fingers dug into my hips as he drove deeper than anyone had before. I came three times before he finally finished, each orgasm more intense than the last.

Paul joined us afterward, reclaiming me as he always does. But it felt different this time. His touch, his size, everything I once found satisfying now seemed lacking in comparison. I feel terrible writing this, knowing Paul might read it someday, but Jean-Marc has ruined me for my husband in some ways.

The worst part? When Jean-Marc was getting ready to leave, he asked if we could do this again. I said yes before Paul could even respond. Jean-Marc is going to be a regular now. I want him — his body, his cock, his sex — in a way that frightens me.

I love Paul. I do. But Jean-Marc makes me feel things Paul never has. I'm not sure what that means for us, but I know I can't give it up now that I've experienced it.

I just hope Paul understands. From the way he reclaimed me afterward — desperate and passionate — I think part of him enjoys the comparison. Maybe that's enough for both of us.

-C

My hands were trembling as I finished that entry. It was so detailed. So vivid. So... brutally honest. Who the fuck was this Claire that I'd been married to? She sounded like a total slut.

But if that was true, why did I click on another journal entry?

Journal Entry: May 12, 2029 — Jean-Marc (Third Time)

I never thought I'd be writing this, but tonight took our arrangement with Jean-Marc to an entirely new level. Paul has been getting more confident, more involved with each session. No longer content to watch from the corner chair, tonight he sat at the edge of the bed while Jean-Marc and I explored each other.

Jean-Marc suggested something we hadn't tried before — me on my hands and knees, him behind me, but this time I was in restraints. A leg-spreader bar kept my ankles apart, and leather wraps around each wrist held me to the bed. The position and lack of control made me feel incredibly vulnerable yet powerful all at once because I could see how turned on Jean-Marc was from how big and hard his cock was, curving upwards, at full attention. I watched Paul's face as Jean-Marc entered me and saw his eyes glimmer with that familiar mixture of jealousy and arousal.

What I didn't expect was for Paul to reach out and touch my face while Jean-Marc thrust into me. The intimacy of that gesture — Paul's fingers tracing my lips while another man used my married pussy — sent me into one of the most intense orgasms I've ever experienced.

But the real surprise came afterward. Jean-Marc had barely finished when Paul practically pushed him aside, grabbed me by the hips, and reclaimed me with a ferocity that left me breathless. I was still full of his cum, but Paul didn't care, shoving into me with his undersized cock, ramming me hard until he came too. Jean-Marc seemed shocked at first, then visibly turned on as he watched Paul fuck me with an almost primal need, marking his territory. When Paul pulled out, his dick was covered with a mixture of both their cum, which was a crazy-hot turn-on for me.

The most surreal moment came later, as we shared a bottle of wine. Paul casually mentioned that his company had an opening for someone with Jean-Marc's technical background. "We could use someone like you," he said. Jean-Marc seemed intrigued, asking questions about the tech they're developing.

I'm not entirely comfortable with the idea of Jean-Marc working alongside Paul every day, given our arrangement. The boundaries between

our personal and professional lives seem to be blurring in ways I hadn't anticipated. But Paul insists it would be perfect — saying Jean-Marc's marketing experience is exactly what they need to promote the project he's been obsessing over.

Is this how Paul processes his emotions? By bringing Jean-Marc closer, making him less of a threat? Or is there something else at play? Whatever his reasons, I can tell Paul's already made up his mind. And judging by Jean-Marc's enthusiasm about me and Paul's work, I suspect he'll accept the offer.

I wonder where this will lead us next.-C

My cock was throbbing in my shorts, but why? I was reading about my ex-wife with another man, her words about my sexual prowess humiliating. But I had to know. I needed to know everything. I scrolled down and selected another random entry.

Journal Entry: September 8, 2029 — The Three of Us

Tonight changed everything. We crossed a line I never thought we would — Harry, Paul and me together.

Wait... What? Harry? I continued reading.

It started innocently enough with drinks at our place. Paul had been hinting at this possibility for weeks, especially after I mentioned Harry's lingering glances. The tension between us had been building all evening — Harry's nervous energy, Paul's excited anticipation, my own curiosity.

Paul suggested we move to the bedroom "to be more comfortable," and somehow, we all knew what that meant. I was nervous at first — Harry is Paul's best friend, after all. What if this ruined their friendship? What if it screwed up their work partnership like it had with Jean-Marc? But the way they looked at me, both wanting me in different ways, made me feel powerful and desired.

Harry was hesitant until Paul encouraged him, telling him it was okay, that he wanted to see this happen. The first kiss was awkward — Harry kept looking at Paul for permission. But then Paul joined us, his hands on my waist from behind while Harry kissed me, and suddenly everything felt right.

Paul undressed me, showing Harry my pussy first, that always feels naughty to him, for some reason. Then taking off my top and bra, asking Harry if he liked my tits. Of course, Harry nodded, his eyes drinking in the sight of my erect nipples and my shaved pussy.

What followed was beyond anything I'd experienced. Being between them, feeling Harry shove his rock hard cock into me while Paul watched, then joined, letting me take him in my mouth, was intoxicating. Once they both started to fuck me, Harry going slowly, savouring the feeling of my pussy, Paul thrusting into my mouth enthusiastically, I came almost instantly. I felt completely consumed with pleasure. Fucking strangers is one thing, but fucking my husband's best friend, the best man at our wedding, just felt deliciously wrong. Paul seemed to feel the same way, transformed watching his best friend fuck me — not jealous but intensely aroused, even encouraging him to cum inside me.

Afterward, Harry's cum leaking from me, Paul's cum drying on my face, we lay tangled together, laughing about how we'd all been thinking about this for months but no one dared to suggest it. Harry admitted he'd fantasized about me since we first met. Paul confessed he'd been hoping for this scenario for weeks.

I don't know what this means for us going forward. The boundaries between friendship and something more have blurred completely. But I know I want to experience this again. The way they worked together to please me, the way Paul and Harry seemed to connect through sharing me — it was perfect.

Paul calls it "compersion" — finding joy in seeing your partner's pleasure with someone else. I'm beginning to understand what he means. Watching him so happy, so deliriously content, awakened something in me I didn't know existed.

Whatever happens next, we've started something that can't be undone. And honestly, I don't want it to be. I just hope it works out better than it did with Jean-Marc.

The only thing we have to work out is what to do about Annmarie.-C

I stared at the screen blankly, unable to believe what I'd just read. Claire. And Harry. And me.

And Annmarie.

Chapter Six

The next morning, I arrived at the office early, my mind still reeling from the revelations of the previous night. As I settled at my desk, the events of the past twenty-four hours washed over me in waves of confusion and guilt.

After reading those journal entries, I was overwhelmed by a mix of emotions — shock, arousal and shame. The vivid descriptions of Claire’s encounters had affected me more than I cared to admit. In a moment of weakness, I had given in, jerking off in the bathroom and cumming spectacularly all over the floor... then immediately regretting it afterwards.

Disgusted with myself, I’d put away Adam’s laptop, trying to push the images from my mind. I made myself a simple dinner, barely tasting it as I ate mechanically in front of the TV. I watched some mindless game show, but I couldn’t recall a single detail of it now. Sleep had been elusive, my dreams a confusing tangle of faces I couldn’t quite recognise.

Now, in the harsh light of day, I felt hollowed out. The office buzzed around me, but I felt disconnected from it all. My eyes kept drifting to Harry’s empty desk, worry gnawing at me. Where was he? And what did these revelations mean for our friendship?

I was so lost in thought that I almost didn’t notice Rachel approaching my desk.

“Early bird,” she said, resting a hand lightly on the edge of my desk. “Didn’t take you for a morning person.”

I glanced up. She was dressed sharply, as always. A cream skirt suit today, the jacket tailored close to her waist, white blouse slightly sheer in the morning light. Her hair was up, a few loose fiery red strands framing her face.

“Couldn’t sleep,” I said. “So I thought I’d get a head start on getting RoomRecall compiled.”

Her smile twitched, like she’d expected something more playful. “Another tough night?”

“Something like that.”

She shifted her weight subtly, one hip easing out just enough to draw the eye. “Well, if you’re looking for a distraction — “

But I didn’t hear the rest. I saw Marcus moving down the hallway, head low, shoulders hunched. The kind of walk that said ‘don’t look at me, I’m busy, I’m invisible.’ He didn’t even glance toward me.

I stood abruptly. “Sorry. I need to — “

I left Rachel mid-sentence. She didn’t call after me.

“Marcus!” I caught up to him just before the elevator. He flinched like I’d startled him, then tried to cover it with a strained smile.

“Paul. Hey.”

“We need to talk. What was that all about, yesterday?”

He looked around, then nodded reluctantly, gesturing toward the empty break room. Inside, he perched on the edge of the counter, arms folded tight across his chest. The early sunlight through the blinds cast pale bars across the room, stripes of shadow over his face.

“Look,” he said before I could speak. “I was wrong. About the security thing. It’s... It’s nothing. Just a bad flag. A false positive.”

I studied him. His voice was too fast, rehearsed. “Then why’d you hang up on me last night?”

He hesitated, pushing his thick-rimmed glasses higher up his nose. “Because I realised I’d wasted your time. I panicked; I don’t know why. I felt like an idiot. I just — “ he stopped, shook his head. “It’s nothing, Paul. I’m sorry.”

I didn’t answer. I just held his gaze. He wouldn’t meet it.

“I’ve got it pinned down to just a few lines of code,” he continued, anxiety evident in his voice. “So there’s no need to worry. It’ll be ironed out today.”

“Marcus,” I started, shaking my head. This wasn’t like the Marcus of yesterday. He’d been on the edge of telling me something significant. “Listen — “

“Everything okay in here?” Rachel interrupted, leaning against the doorframe, a steaming coffee in hand, the smile on her lips not quite reaching her eyes.

Marcus was quick to speak. “Yeah, totally. Just some confusion over a module I flagged. No big deal.”

I watched the way he avoided my face, how his hands fidgeted at the hem of his sleeve. Rachel’s presence gave him cover, and he knew it.

I forced a tight smile. “No big deal.”

Rachel looked between us, waiting to see if anything else would drop. When it didn’t, she took a slow sip of her coffee and wandered off, Marcus scurrying after her as if I terrified him.

Back at my desk, I opened the Cerulean project interface, scanning the tasks. The bug Marcus had supposedly flagged — the module we’d discussed — was now blocked out. Greyed out and inaccessible. A lock icon hovered next to his name. My fingers floated over the keyboard, useless. There was nothing I could do. I’d have to get him alone later and question him further. Something wasn’t right.

Rachel passed by again a little while later, slowed slightly, but didn’t speak. Maybe she could tell I wasn’t in the mood. Or maybe she was just done trying.

My phone buzzed. I looked down to see a message from Sam.

Is tonight still okay? Luciano’s? Dinner is on me. I’d like to explain properly.

I stared at the message longer than necessary. I should have ignored it. But I didn’t.

Yeah. See you then.

I set the phone down and leaned back in my chair. Rachel was right. I needed a distraction but she wasn’t it. However, Sam might be. Either way, I owed her a proper chance to explain. But something was off. Something bigger than Marcus or the module or the countless other reasons for my recent sleepless nights. But, for now, I was going to pretend like everything was fine. Just long enough to get through the day.

I didn't see Marcus again for the rest of the afternoon. His desk sat untouched, monitors dark, coffee cup exactly where he'd left it that morning. No messages, no emails, nothing. It was like he'd simply evaporated. Whatever had spooked him, he clearly didn't want me following up — and that only made me more certain that I should. But it could wait. Not tonight.

I left the office just after six, caught a cab, and let the city blur past the window — headlights streaking like brushstrokes through glass, buildings glowing amber in the dusk. By the time I reached Luciano's, the early evening crowd had already filled the place with that soft, comfortable buzz of cutlery and conversation. A waiter greeted me with the kind of smooth professionalism only the best places could pull off and led me to a small table near the window, where a single candle flickered over crisp white linen.

Sam arrived not long after, and when she walked in, my breath caught in my throat. She looked stunning — a dark green dress, off the shoulder, clinging in a way that wasn't just sexy but confident. Her heels gave her that slow, deliberate posture I always loved, and her hair — down, glossy, loose — brushed her collarbone in soft waves that made me want to reach across the table before she even sat down. She gave me a smile — not the usual playful flash, but something more hopeful. Tentative and warm in a way that hit me square in the chest.

"Hey," she said gently as she slid into the seat across from me. "You look nice."

"You look..." I didn't bother pretending, "Incredible."

We ordered a bottle of wine and something to nibble while we eased into conversation. For a while, it almost felt like everything was fine again, like we were a version of ourselves from months ago, before everything got fucked up. But eventually, as we both knew it would, the thing we'd been avoiding settled quietly between us, waiting to be addressed.

"I still owe you that explanation," she said, her fingers tracing the rim of her glass. "About Raoul."

I didn't push, just gave a slow nod and waited.

“We met through work,” she began. “He’s... well, you’ve seen him. Big, strong, and intense, one of those men who doesn’t take no for an answer. I liked him, but never more than that. We dated, but I never really loved him. However, he felt more for me than I did for him.”

I raised an eyebrow, and she gave a small, almost rueful smile.

“It’s true. It was a physical thing, that’s all. I was lonely when I met him. But when I met you... You were... different. I liked you. I still do. Maybe... maybe, it’s more than like. I care about you, Paul.”

“But not enough to break it off with him,” I countered quietly.

“That’s not true,” she replied, her voice softening. “He wouldn’t let me end it. I told him it was over but he kept getting upset, asking for another chance. And then that night, I told him I was finally ending it with him, once and for all, and this time he realised I meant it. As always, though, he had an answer. One last fuck. One last night with me. If that was what it took to get rid of him, to make a proper relationship with you... I didn’t think straight, Paul. I’d had a drink... And that’s not an excuse for what I did. I just want you to understand why. Raoul was a mistake. But, if I’m being honest, he was also... a really good lover and hard to break away from. I shouldn’t have done what I did, and I’m sorry. I just hope you can find it in yourself to give me a second chance.”

A really good lover. She didn’t try to soften it, didn’t flinch or blush. She said it plainly, like it was just one more piece of the truth she owed me, no matter how sharp it felt going down. I sipped my wine, letting the silence stretch, not because I didn’t have anything to say but because I didn’t trust myself to say it just yet.

“I stayed with him longer than I should have,” she added, her voice lower now. “Because the sex was good. Because I felt wanted. But I never loved him. Not for a second. And that’s the complete and honest truth. No secrets.”

I glanced up at her. “And after I left that night? Did you fuck him?”

“No.” Her answer came fast. “I didn’t sleep with him again. That was it. I went back inside, told him I was yours. I told him I didn’t love him, would never love him. And he left.”

I gave a small nod. I believed her. Or maybe I just wanted to. I thought about Beth — about what I’d done — and didn’t say a word.

She leaned into the silence, softened it. “What about D.C.? How’s your mom?”

“She’s good. Still the same old mom. Still thinks I dress like I’ve given up on life.”

Sam laughed, and it felt genuine. The tightness between us started to dissolve, not completely, but enough that we could finish dinner at our own pace, not rushing, just talking about nothing — memories, nonsense, whatever came to mind. The place had emptied a bit by then, lights dimmed lower, the candle between us flickering against her wine glass.

She leaned forward, voice dropping to something lower, more intimate. “So... I wore my best dress tonight.”

I smiled. “I noticed.”

“And my sexiest underwear,” she added, tilting her head just enough to tease. Her eyes held mine as her fingers brushed my thigh beneath the table. “You’re not going to waste that, are you?”

“Are you offering me one last night to be rid of you?” I grinned.

“Or it could be the first night of many.” Sam shrugged, quirked an eyebrow at me. “Either way, it’ll be a good night, I promise.”

The cab ride home was quiet, but every second buzzed with tension. Sam’s hand rested on my thigh the entire way, her fingertips tracing slow, aimless shapes along the seam of my trousers. She didn’t need to say anything — every touch was a reminder of what she’d told me back at the restaurant. That she was wearing her sexiest underwear. That it wasn’t staying on for long.

By the time we reached my building, I was already semi-hard and barely thinking straight. The moment the door closed behind us, she turned, grabbed the front of my shirt, and pulled me into a kiss that short-circuited everything else. Her mouth was hungry, her tongue urgent, lips parted and hot as she backed me into the hallway. Her hands went straight into my hair, tugging gently like she needed to feel every inch of me at once. Her body pressed full against mine, curves fitting snugly against muscle, her hips rolling just enough to let me feel the heat between her thighs.

“I’ve missed you,” she breathed, her mouth brushing mine.

“I can tell.”

We stumbled into the living room, half-drunk on the chemistry, her heels scratching against the floor until she kicked them off without breaking the kiss. I caught her waist, spun her gently, and guided her down onto the couch with me. She straddled my lap, the green dress riding up her thighs.

Her hands moved to my shirt, her fingers sliding beneath the buttons and peeling the fabric apart to reveal my chest. She kissed me there, just above the sternum, then lower, teasing, her breath hot as she whispered, "It's you that I want, Paul. Not him. I want this."

She shifted her weight slightly and reached between us, her palm pressing against the bulge in my trousers. She rubbed me slowly, her hand firm, eyes fixed on mine as she leaned in again. Her lips brushed my ear.

"Raoul was good in bed, but all I can think about right now is you fucking me right here on this couch. Pulling my dress up. Pushing my panties aside. Just taking me."

I groaned, hard as stone beneath her touch.

"You keep talking like that..." My voice was already rough with it. "I'll cum before you even get it out of my pants."

"Oh, I'm going to make you cum," she murmured, grinding her hips into me. "But not yet."

My hands slid up the backs of her thighs, under the dress, fingers trailing along soft, bare skin until they met the edge of her panties — just a whisper of lace, soaked and clinging. I pressed against her gently, rubbing through the fabric, and she gasped, her body curling toward mine, needy and open.

"Take them off," I said.

She stood, fingers slipping under the hem of her dress. In one slow, smooth motion, she pulled it over her head and tossed it aside, standing before me in barely-there black lace panties and a sheer bra that did nothing to hide the tight peaks of her nipples. She held my gaze as she slid the panties down her legs, stepping out of them without breaking eye contact, then dropped to her knees between mine.

"Wow," I gasped at the sight of her. She smiled, her fingers worked my belt open, freeing my cock. It sprang forward, fully erect, already leaking a drip of pre-cum from the tip.

"I see you've missed me too, Paul."

She wrapped her hand around my cock, slow and deliberate, pumping slowly, teasing me, watching my face the entire time. Her grip was just right as she slid it up and down my shaft, grinning filthily in the best way. I groaned and pulled her back into my lap, guiding her hips with both hands.

The tip of my cock brushed the wetness between her legs, then she parted her pussy lips with her fingers, letting me see the wet, pink softness between and then lowered herself onto me in one slow, controlled

movement that made both of us gasp. Tight, hot, soft—she took me inside her, inch by inch, until I was buried completely in her.

“Fuck...” she whispered, her head falling forward, dark hair spilling over her shoulders. “I forgot how good you feel inside me.”

She started to move, hips rolling in slow, deliberate circles, riding me deep and smooth, her breath coming faster as she found her rhythm. Her bra bounced gently with each motion until I reached behind her and unclasped it, pulling it away and tossing it to the floor, her tits falling free.

I cupped her breasts, thumbs brushing over her dark pink nipples, erect and sensitive beneath my touch. She moaned, louder now, grinding harder, kissing me again — messy, open-mouthed, hungry.

We stayed like that for a while — moving together in that perfect rhythm, lost in the heat, the sweat, the sound of skin on skin, of her pussy slapping against my balls. I pushed my hips up to meet her, every thrust sending a jolt through us both, every grind of her hips making her gasp into my neck.

Then the couch cushions began to slip and us with them, sliding to the floor in a tangle of limbs. She laughed, breathless, her voice thick with lust.

“Upstairs?”

I nodded, barely able to speak. “Yeah. Before we wreck the furniture.”

She climbed off me, sighing as I slid out of her, and took my hand, leading me through the hallway completely naked, unabashed. Still mine, at least for tonight.

She straddled me again as soon as we hit the bed, her legs pinning my hips, her lips finding mine with a hunger that took my breath. Again, she fucked me hard, her hips rocking, grinding against me as she kissed my neck, her breath hot against my skin. I cupped her ass in both hands, feeling the smooth firmness of it, pulling her tighter against me. I kissed her collarbone, then her shoulder, then leaned back just enough to look up at her. For some reason, questions were forming in my head. Whether they were mine, or his — the Paul that I was before — I wasn’t sure, but I asked anyway.

“What do you think about when you touch yourself? Do you think about him? About Raoul?”

Her expression shifted, eyes narrowing slightly as if trying to gauge whether I was angry or aroused. Then she smiled — naughty, knowing.

“You really want to know?”

I nodded, dragging my hands up her thighs. "Yeah. You said he was good in bed. Have you ever thought him fucking you?"

She bit her lip. "Sometimes. I've thought about us fucking too."

I reached up and tugged her hair gently, tilting her head back. Another weird question came from my lips, almost unbidden. "Show me how you sucked his cock."

Her breath hitched. "Seriously?"

"I want to know what it was like," I said. "How you sucked him."

She slid down off me, dropping to her knees beside the bed. My cock was rock hard, thick and pulsing, slick with her juices. She wrapped her fingers around it slowly, eyes locked on mine.

"I've sucked his cock hundreds of times. He likes it when I start slow," she whispered. "When I run my tongue along the underside. Just like this..."

She licked a long, teasing stroke up the length of me, then swirled her tongue around the head. I groaned, fingers clenching the sheets.

"He likes it when I look up at him," she said. "Likes when I make it messy."

She spat on my cock, twice, then opened her mouth and took me in deeper, sucking harder now, her lips slick, her eyes wicked. I grabbed her hair, not pulling, just holding her there, watching the way her cheeks hollowed, how wet her chin was already.

"Fuck..." I muttered. "That's how you did it, huh?"

She pulled off, breathless. "You tell me. You watched, didn't you?"

I froze.

She smiled, slowly. "How long were you standing there?"

"Long enough."

"And if I hadn't seen you?" she asked, running her tongue around the head. "Would you have stayed? Even if I'd let him fuck me?"

I looked down at her, throat tight. "Yeah," I admitted.

"You'd have watched us fuck?" she asked, climbing back onto the bed, curiosity filling her gaze. "Even though it hurt? Even though I was cheating on you? Wouldn't you have stopped us?"

I pulled her down and kissed her hard. "Honestly... I don't know."

She straddled me again, guided me inside her, her pussy gripping me tightly. Then she started moving fast, rough, grinding her clit against me with every stroke. We fucked like she wanted to erase Raoul and I wanted

to replace Claire. It was messy and real and full of heat. She came first, her fingers rubbing her clit as she bounced on me and I followed soon after, cumming hard, filling her pussy with my seed. Then we collapsed to the bed, tangled together in the dark, sweat-slicked and gasping for breath.

After a while, she curled against me, her leg draped over mine.

“That was crazy,” she whispered.

I nodded, but my mind was already somewhere else. The questions were gone, replaced by something else. A need for honesty. She’d been honest. I should return the favour. I’d kept things from Sam. I shouldn’t hold them back anymore.

“I need to tell you something,” I said.

She lifted her head slightly. “Okay...”

“The real reason I went to D.C.... It wasn’t just to see my mom.”

She waited.

“I was... trying to remember something. Someone. I told you I think my memories were wiped. On my PC, I found a folder with loads of files in it... journal entries, photos, videos, messages from someone I used to know. Someone I think I loved.”

Sam stared at me, eyes hardening.

“What are you talking about?”

“I had a wife,” I said. “I didn’t know until recently. Her name was Claire.”

She sat up, the warmth between us cooling fast.

“You’re serious?”

“We’re divorced now, I think. But, Sam, I promise. I didn’t know. Not until recently. I swear.”

“And you didn’t think to tell me?” Her voice was sharp now, wounded. “You let me think this memory thing wasn’t anything serious. You let me think... that we were — what, starting over? When you’ve got a whole erased marriage behind you? And you were trying to get those memories back?”

“I didn’t mean to keep it from you,” I said defensively. “I was waiting for the right time.”

“But you did keep it from me,” she said flatly. “You lied every time I asked if you were okay. Every time I wondered what was wrong, you just brushed it off. You let me fuck you just now... like it meant something.”

“It does mean something.”

She shook her head, already pulling the sheet around her. “You didn’t trust me enough to tell me... So, I don’t know if I believe that anymore.”

“And you didn’t trust me enough to tell me about Raoul.”

She sat on the edge of the bed, wrapped in the sheet like it was a shield, her body angled away but her eyes locked on mine — sharp, wet with held-back tears, accusing. I sat up slowly, elbows on my knees, my head hanging for a beat before I forced myself to look at her. My mouth was dry. My thoughts were scattered. But I knew I had to say it.

“Sam... this is bigger than a secret I kept. It’s not just about Claire.”

She didn’t move, didn’t speak — just stared, waiting. I couldn’t tell if she was bracing for an excuse or was already done listening.

“On the way back from D.C., I was followed,” I said finally. “I’m being watched. My phone, my car, my laptop — they’ve all been tapped. Or were. I think I was part of an experiment. Something called *Fresh Start*, run by a company called Elysium.”

She blinked once, slow, like she was trying to process the words in order. “You think you’re in an experiment?”

“I don’t think,” I said quietly. “I know. And I’m not the only one. Harry too. We were involved in it somehow. Maybe volunteers. I don’t remember how deep it goes yet, but someone — Claire, maybe — left a trail. A way back. I don’t want her back. I just want to know the truth, that’s all.”

Sam stood up abruptly, the sheet slipping off her without her noticing or caring. She was suddenly pacing, naked and furious and impossible to look away from, all sharp edges and vulnerability wrapped in heat.

“This is insane,” she said, her voice rising. “An experiment? An ex-wife leaving you a way back... Paul, you sound... not okay. Like a conspiracy theorist or something.”

“I know how it sounds,” I said, grabbing my boxers from the floor, needing something to do with my hands. “But it’s real. I’ve got the files and messages to prove it. I’ve been working with a guy named Adam and a woman called Nadia — “

“Nadia?” she repeated, tone flat.

I hesitated. That split second was all it took.

Her arms crossed over her chest. Her voice dropped an octave and sharpened. “Who the fuck is Nadia?”

“She’s a neuroscientist,” I said carefully, keeping my voice calm. “She used to work for Elysium. She’s been helping me put things together.”

Sam laughed, but it came out bitter and humourless. “Of course she has.”

Then, the worst thing that could have possibly happened happened. Her eyes scanned the room like she was looking for proof she didn’t even need. And, of course, she found it. She stormed to the pile of laundry that I’d forgotten to move and picked up the delicate black bra.

Her face went cold, then flushed red with anger. “Is this hers?”

Shit. I opened my mouth. Closed it. I couldn’t say it was Beth’s. Couldn’t say anything at all.

“Because it certainly isn’t fucking mine. Wow,” she muttered, backing away like I’d hit her. “I came here. I trusted you. I wanted you to give me another chance. And in return, you let me suck your cock on the same couch, fuck you in the same bed you fucked someone else on?”

“Just like you and Raoul... It’s not what it looks like,” I said quickly, already hearing how pathetic it sounded.

She held the bra up like it was a weapon. “Really? Because this looks exactly like what it looks like, Paul. You made me feel like shit for what happened with Raoul and the whole time you’ve been fucking someone else too.”

“It’s complicated.”

“No,” she snapped. “It’s not. You lied. You’re still lying. And I must be a fucking idiot for thinking you were someone worth fighting for.”

She grabbed her dress from the floor and yanked it over her head, not even bothering with her underwear. At the door, she paused just long enough to deliver one last, deliberate cut.

“Oh — and since we’re being honest?” she said, looking back at me with something between pity and contempt. “Yeah. I did fuck Raoul after you left. I fucked him all fucking night long. And he was fucking amazing. I sucked his cock, rode him, he even fucked me in the ass. And he made me cum in ways you never could.”

The door slammed behind her like a gunshot.

I stood there, in the middle of the room, the air still warm with sex and everything else broken around me — clothes on the floor, the bed sheets rumpled, memories I couldn’t trust. I didn’t even know what I was doing anymore. Or why.

I stayed sitting on the edge of the bed long after Sam had gone, staring at the door as if it might open again, as if she might step back inside and say something else — anything to take the sting out of what she’d left behind.

He was fucking amazing.

The words clanged around in my head, louder than they should have been, heavier than I wanted them to be.

He made me cum in ways you never could.

I wasn't even angry. Not jealous, exactly. Just hollow. Like something important had slipped through my fingers and shattered somewhere I couldn't reach. I'd told her too much... or maybe not enough. Maybe I'd waited too long to tell her anything at all.

Eventually, I reached for my phone and typed out a message without thinking.

I gave you the chance to explain. You owe me the same. Please, Sam.

I stared at the words, thumb hanging over the send button for a few seconds, then hit it. The delivered icon popped up right away, neat and indifferent.

Then nothing.

I sat there like an idiot, watching the screen, refreshing the thread, waiting for the typing bubbles to appear. They never did.

After a while I got up and pulled on a pair of sweatpants, went to the kitchen and filled a glass of water I didn't want. The city outside looked the same as always — blurred lights, motionless towers. But the apartment felt quieter than usual. Not just quiet — emptier. Like something had left with her and wasn't coming back.

When the doorbell rang, it startled me enough that I nearly dropped the glass.

I moved to the door without thinking, my heart kicking up in my chest. Sam had come back, had changed her mind, had something else to say. An apology. A second chance for me to explain. Anything but silence.

But it wasn't Sam.

It was Rachel.

She stood on the doorstep, her posture unsure, her face streaked with running mascara. Her hair was loose for once, falling in soft, wind-tangled waves around her face. No blazer, no heels, no crisp office power clothes. She was wearing a tight black top and a short denim skirt — something that clung to her figure in a way I'd never seen on her before. It would've been sexy if not for the way she looked — wrecked, glassy-eyed, her expression raw and embarrassed.

"Rachel?" I blinked. "Are you okay?"

She gave a weak laugh that cracked halfway through and wiped under her nose with the heel of her hand. “No. Not really. I’m sorry for just turning up like this but...”

I didn’t ask anything else. I just stepped aside and let her in. She walked past me slowly, moving like she was trying to hold herself together and wasn’t sure how much longer she could.

“I was out with my boyfriend,” she said, once she reached the living room, not looking at me. “We went to this shitty rooftop place in Midtown. He started flirting with the waitress. Right in front of me.”

She sank onto the edge of the couch, arms folded tight over her modest chest like she was keeping herself from falling apart.

“I lost it. We argued. It got... ugly. I walked out. He followed me for a bit and said some things I’d rather not repeat. And I didn’t want to go home after that. I didn’t know where else to go.”

I closed the door behind us quietly.

“I didn’t even know you knew where I lived, but, sure,” I said. “You can crash here if that’s what you need.”

She nodded faintly, not looking at me yet. “Thanks.” She wiped at her face again, only managing to smear the mascara more, and when I handed her a tissue from the counter, she took it with a sad chuckle. “I must look like a complete mess.”

“You don’t,” I said, though we both knew it wasn’t entirely true. She was still Rachel — just not the version I was used to. Not the one who strutted into conference rooms with spreadsheets and thin smiles. This one was real. Frayed. Unmasked. And beautiful in a way that I hadn’t noticed before.

Rachel dabbed at her eyes again, then let the tissue fall into her lap, twisting it idly between her fingers. The quiet stretched on until she finally spoke, her voice low and raw.

“He didn’t hit me,” she said. “But I think... I think he might have if I hadn’t walked away when I did. That’s why I can’t go home. Not until I know he’s not there.”

That landed hard. My stomach turned, and I moved closer without thinking, perching on the arm of the couch beside her. “Jesus. Rachel, you think he might hit you? Is he that type of guy? Fuck, that’s not okay. Even if he didn’t actually touch you — did he threaten to?”

She shook her head and cut me off gently, brushing a strand of hair back from her face with a shaky hand. “He didn’t say it outright, nothing that

clear, but it was in the way he looked at me. Angry, like I'd done something wrong. Like whatever happened next would be my fault." She swallowed. "And I believed it, for a second. That was the part that scared me."

I sat there beside her, not sure what to say. I didn't know how to feel, but an emotion was welling up inside — not lust, not pity either. Just a sharp, protective instinct that hadn't been there earlier. A need to keep her from cracking any further.

She looked up at me, her eyes still rimmed red but more focused now. "You said I could stay?"

"Of course," I said. "I have a guest room. You can stay here until we work this out."

Rachel looked around the room like she was only just noticing it now, then her gaze drifted back to me — and lingered. I remembered, belatedly, that I was still shirtless, barefoot, wearing only a pair of sweats that clung a little too low on my hips.

She gave me a tired, crooked smile. "Am I interrupting something? Is there someone here? If there is, I can go."

"No. There was but..." I exhaled, leaning forward to grab the bottle of wine I'd left on the coffee table. I unscrewed the cap and took a long sip directly from the bottle. Maybe it was the wine or just everything unravelling at once, but the words came easier than I expected. "Sam and I were... working things out, but it went badly. We argued, and she left not long before you got her. It's not looking good for us."

Rachel raised an eyebrow. "Do you want to talk about it?"

"She cheated on me." The words tumbled out. I needed to get this off my chest. "I cheated on her back. We'd just had sex, and then she noticed the bra... the bra of the woman who I... Well, you can imagine."

She chuckled softly, her voice low. "Ouch, that's a shame. I never had you down as the type to cheat. Well, I hope the sex was good. With Sam... and the woman you cheated with. Hey, at least you got some. I was horny as hell and looking forward to getting fucked tonight — until all that shit happened."

I blinked, surprised by the bluntness of it. Rachel had always been professional at work, flirtatious on occasion, but never like this — never openly sexual. She was looser now, messier, stripped of the confines of workplace rules. She suddenly looked hot. Flushed, damp hair curling

slightly around her face, tight top stretched across her chest, bare legs tucked up under her.

I shook my head slightly, trying to refocus. “It wasn’t just about the bra. I’ve got something going on, Rachel. Something really fucking weird. The company that invested in RoomRecall, Elysium? I think they’ve been watching me. I think I’m somehow connected to them.”

I found myself telling her the full story. Rachel sat there, listening intently, any flirtation faded. Her brows pulled together as she studied my face. “Wait — what? You’re serious?”

I nodded, raking a hand through my hair. “I’m trying to figure out how to get my memories back. Sam hated that I used to have a wife. She hated that I kept it all from her. It’s a mess, Rachel. It’s a massive fucking mess. My entire life is fucked up. Harry’s missing. I’ve lost Sam, I don’t know what the hell I’m doing.”

She was quiet for a beat, absorbing it. Then she let out a slow breath. “Holy shit, Paul. That’s... wow. That’s huge.”

“Yeah.”

Rachel bit her lip, eyes searching mine. Then, out of nowhere, she joked, “Still, as I said, look at the bright side. At least one of us got laid tonight.”

I looked up at her with a smile. Her smirk had returned, but it was different now. Not office banter. Something heavier. More dangerous.

“I’m sorry,” she said, though she clearly wasn’t. “I’m just... trying to lighten the mood. I don’t know about any of that Elysium stuff but I do know that I’m still kind of horny. I’m not used to seeing you like this. Shirtless, all moody and wounded. It’s kind of hot.”

I let out a short laugh, more from tension than amusement. “Rachel... I know what you’re suggesting, and it would be a bad idea.”

She stood slowly and crossed the space between us, letting her fingers trail along my shoulder as she passed. “You sure? Because I’m pretty fucking wound up. I’m here, somehow... and you’re here. I’m horny. Aren’t you?”

She leaned in, her breath warm against my neck, close enough that her body brushed mine. I almost kissed her. Almost.

But I pulled back, just barely.

“Still a bad idea,” I murmured.

She looked at me for a long second, searching my face, then gave a slow nod. “You’re right. It *is* a bad idea. Doesn’t mean I don’t want to fuck you

though.”

“You’re drunk, Rachel. Maybe we pick this up sometime when you’re sober?”

“You’re right.” Her voice had softened again, the edge retreating. She turned toward the stairs, pausing only briefly. “Mind if I take a shower? It might, you know... Cool me off a bit?”

“Yeah,” I said, rising. “Top of the stairs, first door on the right.”

I grabbed a towel from the linen cupboard and passed it to her. She took it without a word and padded up the stairs, bare feet quiet against the wood. I collapsed back onto the couch, staring at nothing, my thoughts still tangled. The temptation was still buzzing in my veins, but it was mixed now with suspicion, confusion, too many shifting pieces I couldn’t line up.

Minutes passed. I could hear the water running, steam beginning to trail down the hall. I let my head fall back, dozing for a few moments until a little while later, I wasn’t sure how long, her voice floated down from upstairs, soft and casual. “Paul? You got something I can wear? A T-shirt or something?”

I went to my room, pulled one from the drawer — a plain grey tee that I sometimes wore to bed — and headed towards the bathroom. The door was ajar, steam billowing out. I should have called through the door, told her that I’d left the shirt outside but I didn’t. Instead, I leaned through, holding the garment in front of me.

Rachel stood inside, completely naked, drying her legs with the towel, her back to me. Her hair hung in wet, dark strands, clinging to the curve of her spine. When she turned and saw me, she didn’t flinch, didn’t cover up. Just smiled.

“Thanks,” she said quietly.

I stepped in, holding out the shirt. She didn’t take it right away. Her hand brushed mine as she reached, and her gaze didn’t break. Her tits were smaller than Sam’s but still a nice size, perky and high. Her nipples were a light pink, her tits flushed with pale freckles.

“Thank you”, she said, her voice lower, huskier. “Do you like what you see? You sure are having a good look.”

I looked at her — really looked — and felt the heat stirring again, fast and real. Her body was lean, not an ounce of fat. Her pussy had just the lightest dusting of reddish hair. Her legs were slim and long. She was stunning. Wet skin, gleaming curves, lips parted just slightly. I was hard

before I even noticed, her eyes looking down at the bulge in the front of my sweats.

“Are you sure you still want to be good?” she said softly.

“I’m not going to lie. I’m tempted,” I said. “But I shouldn’t.”

She stepped in close again, her tits brushing against me, warm and bare, and kissed me — soft, slow, not demanding but tempting. I let it happen, let it linger, enjoying the taste of her mouth. Her hand slipped down the front of my sweatpants, finding and taking hold of my cock, wanking me slowly as we made out.

Then I broke the kiss, stopping things again before they could start.

“Not tonight,” I said, pulling away, breath catching, pulling up my sweatpants where she’d tugged them down at the front. “We’re both drunk. We might regret it at work tomorrow.”

She stepped back this time, took the shirt without comment, and pulled it on. It hung loose around her hips. Then she smiled, more genuinely this time. “Okay. You’re right. You keep being right, Paul. You’re good at being right. Maybe you should try being wrong for once.”

With that, Rachel disappeared further into the bathroom with the T-shirt clutched in her hand, and I didn’t follow, giving myself a few minutes to calm down. Then I headed to the kitchen and started throwing together something simple — just grilled cheese sandwiches, comfort food, the kind you could make half-asleep. I wasn’t sure if she’d want any, but cooking gave me something to do with my hands. Something that didn’t involve replaying everything that had happened in the last few hours on a loop.

She came downstairs just as I was plating it, her legs bare beneath the hem of my oversized T-shirt, sleeves hanging past her elbows. She looked more relaxed now, face cleansed, cheeks pink from the steam, hair twisted up into a lazy bun. Her makeup was mostly gone, the streaks of mascara removed.

“You made grilled cheese?” Rachel said as she walked back into the kitchen, her tone a mix of surprise and amusement.

“Don’t get used to it,” I muttered, sliding a plate across the counter to her. “This is the full extent of my culinary ambitions.”

She gave a faint smile, something softer than her usual smirk, and climbed onto one of the stools at the kitchen island. We ate in silence but it wasn’t awkward, just quiet in a way that felt almost earned, like after too much noise, we were both willing to settle into the lull.

After a few bites, she leaned back in her chair with a sigh, nursing her glass of water between both hands. “We really are a pair of sad sacks, huh?”

I looked up at her, chewing slowly. “What do you mean?”

She shrugged, the corner of her mouth twitching. “You just got dumped after opening up and spilling your soul, and I... Well, I got dumped in the middle of a bar and ended up crying on the doorstep of the nearest half-naked man I could find. Not exactly a Hallmark ending.”

I gave a dry chuckle. “Yeah. But at least the grilled cheese is decent.”

She raised her glass in a lazy toast. “Best thing that’s happened to me tonight. Which doesn’t say much.”

We took our time finishing the meal. The wine buzz I’d been nursing since Sam left had mostly faded by now, replaced by a sluggish heaviness, and after we cleared the plates, I decided it was time for bed and showed her to the guest room, flipping on the light and gesturing inside.

“The bed’s made. Extra blankets are in the closet, and the guest bathroom’s just across the hall.”

She hovered in the doorway for a beat, like she might say something more, but then she just gave a small, tired smile and nodded. “Thanks, Paul. Really.”

“Get some sleep,” I said, my voice lower than I intended. “Try, at least.”

With that, she disappeared inside, and I returned to my room, collapsing onto the mattress. I stared at the ceiling for what felt like hours. Sam’s voice, her anger, the sound of betrayal, echoed in my head, Rachel’s kiss lingered on my lips, the sight of her naked body making my cock stiffen again. Eventually, the swirl of thoughts dulled, and I must have drifted off, although I wasn’t sure what time.

But then something woke me. A sound. Subtle. Nothing loud or jarring, just a shift in the quiet — a faint creak, movement downstairs. I sat up slowly, rubbing my eyes. There was no light under the bedroom door, the sound that had woke me was gone, but something felt different.

Barefoot, I padded quietly down the stairs, careful with each step, guided only by the faint glow spilling from the living room. The screen of my PC. I hadn’t turned it on tonight, so who had?

Rachel was sitting at my desk, her back to me, shoulders hunched forward, fingers still poised over the keyboard. When I spoke her name, she flinched, minimising the window she’d had open and spun in the chair, eyes wide, as if I’d caught her mid-theft.

“Rachel?”

She tried to laugh it off. “Oh, shit — you scared me.”

“What are you doing?”

“My phone died,” she said quickly, holding it up as a vague gesture to show me the screen was dark. “I didn’t want to wake you to ask for a charger. I just needed to send a quick email to my boyfriend. Or ex. Whatever he is now.”

I said nothing, eyes shifting to the screen, trying to see what she’d actually been doing, but she subtly angled her body between me and the monitor.

“I didn’t think you’d mind,” she added, smiling faintly.

I forced a nod, though my jaw was tight. “I don’t mind. Just... next time, wake me. I’ve had enough of secrets and people sneaking around.”

She held my gaze a moment longer, then gave that same tight little smile, the one she wore at work like she didn’t want to let something slip. “I’m sorry if I overstepped,” she said, standing and brushing past me, her phone in hand, like nothing was wrong. “Didn’t mean to freak you out.”

I looked back at the monitor. The desktop was empty — suspiciously so. Nothing open. No windows. No emails. I turned to look at her, still trying to read her face. She gave me a smile that didn’t reach her eyes, soft and meaningless.

“It’s fine,” I said, but my voice sounded hollow, disconnected even to my own ears.

She shrugged and ran a hand through her still-damp hair. “Anyway, it doesn’t matter now. Just as you came downstairs, my friend just messaged me — said I can stay at hers. She’s back in the city.”

That caught me off guard. “Now?”

Rachel was already moving, and I followed her, heading back toward the guest room. “Yeah. She’s downtown, it’s not far. I’ll grab a ride. No big deal.”

She spoke like it was nothing, like her tears and the vulnerability from earlier had been a different person entirely. She was moving quickly now, slipping into her denim skirt, gathering her shoes and bag swiftly, suddenly in control. Something about the abruptness of it, the suddenness, felt off. Like a scene ending before the actors had finished saying their lines.

“You sure you’re okay?” I asked, watching her, still trying to piece it all together.

“Totally,” she said brightly, tugging the hem of the borrowed T-shirt down as she moved toward the door. “Thanks for everything. You’ve been sweet. I’ll see you at work tomorrow. I’ll bring the shirt back.”

She smiled again, and that was it. No more breakdown. No lingering need. Just... an exit.

I walked with her to the door, still caught in the speed of everything happening so fast. She stepped outside barefoot, heels dangling from one hand, her phone loose in the other.

“Night, Paul,” she said, tossing the words over her shoulder with a practiced ease. “Sleep well, and thanks again.”

I stood there a moment after the door clicked shut, the silence in the apartment suddenly louder than before. Something wasn’t right. I knew it in my gut.

Moving to the window, I pulled the curtain back just a sliver and watched as she strolled down the street, unhurried and oddly calm, like a woman who had just completed a task, not fled an argument.

And then she did it — subtle, smooth, but unmistakable. Without breaking stride, she lifted her phone and tapped the screen. It lit up instantly. Her phone wasn’t out of charge. It had never died.

I watched until she turned the corner and disappeared, swallowed by the night.

Whatever she came here for, it hadn’t been comfort.

And I’d just handed it to her.

Chapter Seven

I woke before dawn, the room still dark. The only light came from the blue LED night light built into the wall over the door. The dim hum of cars in the distance broke the silence, but it wasn't enough to keep my mind from racing. I stared up at the ceiling, my thoughts a snarled mess of paranoia, guilt, and unanswered questions. My sleep had been restless and fleeting. I'd spent most of the night tossing and turning, trying to untangle the threads of everything that had happened.

Rachel's unexpected visit lingered heavily in my mind. Her tearful vulnerability had felt genuine, but her actions later, sneaking around, using my PC, then leaving like she had, didn't sit right. And then there was Marcus, still silent, refusing to answer my calls or texts. What was he hiding? What was he so afraid of? And Harry... God, Harry, I hadn't heard from him in days. Was he okay? Where had he gone?

As for Sam... I swallowed hard, rolling onto my side as guilt crept in like an unwelcome guest. How had I let things go so wrong with her? I replayed her storming out of my apartment, her anger, her pain when she found Beth's bra. I should have explained better — would it have mattered? Still, I couldn't escape the depressing sense that I'd failed her.

Unable to lie still any longer, I swung my legs over the side of the bed and sat for a moment, rubbing my eyes. My body felt sluggish, and my head hurt. I stood and made my way to the kitchen, the cool tiles chilling my bare feet on the way.

Breakfast was a perfunctory affair — a slice of toast with peanut butter and a cup of black coffee. I didn't have an appetite, but I needed something to keep me moving. As I chewed, I stared at my phone, debating whether to call Harry for the hundredth time. It didn't matter — my fingers moved automatically. The line rang out again, the silence on the other end feeding my frustration. Voicemail. I hung up before I could hear the beep.

I needed answers. Grabbing my phone, I dialled Beth next, hoping she could shed any light on Harry's disappearance. She answered after the second ring, her voice full of concern.

"Paul?" she said, rushing the word, likely anxious as to why I was calling this early in the morning. "Is everything okay?"

"Hey, Beth," I replied, feeling bad for worrying her. "I didn't wake you, did I? I was just wondering, have you heard from Harry? He wasn't at work yesterday. He's sick, apparently."

"No," she said, her voice trembling. "I haven't heard from him either. If he's sick, I don't get it because he doesn't seem to be at home. I'm worried for him, Paul. This isn't like him. He wouldn't just disappear like this."

"I'm sure he'll turn up," I said gently, though my stomach churned. "Maybe he just needs time."

Beth exhaled shakily, but the sigh felt weighted. "I don't know. What, with this Annmarie thing... and all the other stuff he's been mumbling in his sleep."

"What was the other stuff?" I asked out of curiosity. Perhaps whatever he'd been saying might give us a clue as to where he'd gone.

"Random words," Beth replied. "I wrote some of them down. Hold on." The phone went quiet for a moment before she continued. "Secret Etch, whatever that is. Chore Reach, another weird one. Is that a place? And one more word I couldn't catch. He repeated that quite a few times. I've been trying to figure out what they mean — do they make any sense to you?"

I frowned, the words sticking in my mind like glue. *Secret etch. Chore reach*. They weren't random, of that much I was sure. My brain was pounding, but I turned the words over in my mind. They meant nothing. Did Harry know more about our past than I did?

"Beth..." I started hesitantly. "There's something else I need to tell you, just in case anything gets back to you."

"What is it?" she asked, worry thick in her voice.

“Last night, Sam and I had an argument,” I admitted, swallowing against the guilt rising in my throat. “She found your bra in my apartment. We were... making up, after what happened with that guy, and then... *shit*... she found your bra. My bad. I forgot to hide it.”

Beth was quiet for a while. “Oh, fuck,” she said finally, her voice soft and sincere. “I didn’t mean to... you know, make trouble between you and her. I knew I’d forgotten it but... *Fuck*. I should have come over and collected it. I’m sorry. Does she know it’s mine?”

“No, of course not. She didn’t give me time to explain, but even if she had, I wouldn’t have dropped you in it. Look, don’t worry, it’s not your fault,” I said quickly, but the words felt hollow. “She’s just... I don’t know, I think things are pretty fucked up between us now. I told her some other things that upset her, the memory wipe. She wasn’t happy that I’d kept it from her, particularly the bit about me having an ex-wife.”

“Oh, Paul. You really are in trouble,” Beth sighed sympathetically. “Talk to her. If you can forgive her for what happened with that guy, she should be able to find it inside herself to forgive you too.”

“Yeah, I don’t think it quite works that way. Not with Sam.”

“You don’t know if you don’t try. Hey, if you want, I can come by later and pick up the bra,” Beth offered. “We could talk about Harry and all the shit you’ve got going on, and... no funny business, this time, I promise. Just as friends, Paul.”

“No funny business,” I echoed, the faintest trace of a smile tugging at my lips. “Maybe. I’ll call you later. Maybe I’ll get to work today, and Harry will be there. Thanks, Beth.”

After hanging up, I stared at the phone for a long moment, the words she’d told me repeating in my head like an incantation. *Secret etch. Chore reach. Something else.* Wait. Maybe they weren’t word pairs. Perhaps they were individual words, like Claire’s safe word sequence. If Claire had told me her sequence, had I passed mine on too, given them to Harry? But if that was right, what was the last word? Claire’s safeword sequence had five words. What was the last word that Beth hadn’t been able to make out?

I decided to call Adam next, desperate to make sense of it all. I got out the secure laptop he’d given me and voice-called him, not eager to show him my tired and worried face. His voice was sharp and steady when he answered. I needed to tell him about last night, too.

“Good morning. It’s early, Paul. Are you okay?”

“I think so,” I said with a long sigh. “But something happened last night. Rachel, a woman I work with, showed up at my place unexpectedly. She made out she’d been in a fight with her boyfriend but later, she was acting strangely. I caught her on my PC and when I asked what she was doing, she made a bullshit excuse and left. I’d already deleted the files that Claire left, but even so, I’m worried.”

Adam’s tone hardened instantly. “Then you need to stay away from her. You say you work with her? If you’ve got any suspicions about this Rachel woman, don’t go back to work. It might be nothing, but if Elysium is involved with what you’re working on, they’ll be watching you, and it could be this Rachel woman who’s acting as their eyes and ears. If you go into work, you could be putting yourself in danger, especially if you let her know that you’re onto her.”

“I don’t think anything will happen,” I countered, but my voice lacked conviction. “I need to go in. You said it was important to maintain normality. I also need to talk to Marcus and try to find Harry. He’s still not answering my calls.”

Adam sighed heavily. “Paul, listen to me — ”

“Trust me,” I interrupted him. Going to work couldn’t be that dangerous, could it? Surely nothing could happen to me in a public place like the TechSphere office. “I’ll be okay. Oh, and there’s something else. Talking about Harry, his girlfriend told me some of the other things he’d been saying in his sleep. The same random words, over and over, she said. Secret, Etch, Chore, Reach, and some others. Do you think — ”

“Yes, I do. It could be your safe word sequence,” Adam interrupted. “Or his. Write them down so you don’t forget them.”

“Secret, Etch, Chore, Reach,” I repeated slowly, but nothing happened. Maybe I needed the last word.

Adam’s voice dropped, his tone serious. “Paul, stop. Don’t do anything with them. Not until we’re certain. The Safe Word Protocols are delicate. Use them recklessly, and you could damage your mind permanently.”

I exhaled sharply, frustration bubbling beneath the surface.

“Look, meet me tonight,” Adam said firmly. “I’m staying in New York for a few days more. Come to The Nest after work. It’s secure. The address is coded into NOVA, your car’s AI. We can talk about what Harry’s girlfriend told you, and you can update me on this woman at work and how your day went today.”

I agreed, then signed off and put my laptop back in its hiding spot in the dresser while I got dressed, then stopped. After last night's unsettling encounter with Rachel, that didn't feel like enough of a safe place to hide it anymore. I couldn't take any chances. If someone came snooping around my apartment while I was at work or sometime in the future, like Rachel, I couldn't risk them finding it — and the files kept on it. I had a better hiding place than that.

Kneeling on the floor beside my bed, I searched for the loose floorboard that I'd stumbled upon a while back while cleaning under the bed. My fingers brushed over the edge of the slightly raised piece of wood, finding the small gap at the side of it, and I pried it carefully upward, the floorboard creaking faintly as it gave way. Beneath it, the space was just deep enough to hold the laptop, its sleek case fitting snugly into the hollow.

I stared at it for a moment, hesitating. Was this good enough? Could they use some sort of scanner to find it? Either way, I had nowhere better, so I shook the thought off, pressing the board firmly back into place. It clicked into the groove easily, leaving no sign of disturbance, the laptop entirely hidden.

Done. I could shower now. I exhaled sharply and stood, then I froze as movement caught my eye in the doorway. Haley was standing there, cleaning supplies in hand, her expression curious as she tilted her head slightly.

"Paul?" she asked, her voice light but questioning. "Are you okay?"

I straightened quickly, forcing a smile. "Just fixing something. My bed. One of the legs was wobbly."

Haley frowned slightly, stepping further into the room. Her honey-blond hair was pulled back neatly, but a few loose strands framed her face. "A wobbly leg?" she repeated, glancing toward the bed then smiling at me. "Do you want me to try fixing it? I'm quite handy with stuff like that."

"No, it's fine. Maybe I need a new bed. This one has seen a bit of... action, lately," I said, hoping the sexual reference would deflect her curiosity.

"Hmm, I gathered that," she murmured, her gaze lingering on the floor for a moment longer before she turned her attention back to me, flashing me another smile. Damn. She was good-looking when she smiled. How had I never really noticed before? "I did find a bra the other day. Things must be going well with your girlfriend."

I hesitated, debating how much to say. “Well, they were. Until last night.”

Haley studied me for a beat, her lips pressing together slightly. “Oh. That doesn’t sound good.”

I shook my head, glad that I’d managed to distract her from the secret hiding spot I’d been crouched over moments ago. “The course of true love never runs smooth, so they say. Listen, Haley, could you do me a favour?”

“True love,” she said, her tone teasing but threaded with genuine curiosity. “Is that what it is? Between you and your girlfriend? That’s nice, if so.”

“I don’t think so. Even if it was, things aren’t great, but don’t worry. I’ll be fine either way.” I shrugged, reluctant to tell my cleaner about my love life problems. “By the way, I had a thought on what we talked about the other day and starting this Friday, I’m increasing your wages by ten percent. Is that enough?”

Her eyes widened slightly, and a smile broke across her face, her blue eyes crinkling at the corners. “Seriously?”

“Seriously,” I confirmed, smiling back. “You’ve been working hard. It’s more than earned.”

The excitement in her expression was enough to distract her from whatever lingering concerns she had about my relationship. “Wow,” she said, laughing softly. “Thank you, Paul. That’s... really kind of you.”

“Just doing what’s fair,” I replied, moving past her toward the doorway. “I’ll be heading out soon. Got some things to take care of.”

She nodded, her happiness still evident, though a flicker of curiosity remained in her gaze. I could only hope the promise of a higher wage kept her mind off whatever else she might’ve seen me doing under the bed and why a random bra had turned up in the laundry.

After a shower, I got dressed while Haley went about her cleaning tasks, but as I stepped out into the crisp morning air, my mind was anything but clear. The walk to my car felt longer somehow. Every step brought with it flashes of paranoia — memories of Rachel standing in my apartment, the way she’d smiled and fumbled her way through excuses, and the way everything about her had felt wrong. Was she involved in all of this, or was I overthinking again? I needed to know, and the only way to do that was to face her again, despite Adam’s concerns.

The ride to the office was uneventful, but my thoughts wouldn't stop tumbling in circles. By the time I pulled into the lot and climbed out, my nerves were shot with anticipation. Walking into the office felt surreal, like I was stepping back into something I couldn't see but could feel looming just under the surface.

But everything was normal. Quiet. Mundane.

Coworkers buzzed around as usual, typing, chatting, sipping coffee from office mugs. No strange looks. No whispers. Just the hum of ordinary TechSphere office life.

Rachel was at her desk when I arrived, her red hair neat and tucked behind her ear, the sharp angles of her blazer pristine as if last night's messy events had never happened. She spotted me as I approached and smiled, her expression lighter, more genuine — disarming, maybe even comforting.

"Paul," she greeted warmly. "Thanks for looking after me last night. I needed someone, and you were there. I appreciate it."

I studied her for a beat, searching for the cracks beneath the surface. "You were upset," I said carefully. "I'd never turn away a friend in need. Were you okay getting to your friend's house?"

Rachel's smile faltered briefly, replaced by a flicker of something — embarrassment? "Yes. It was only a few blocks away. I should have gone to her house straight away, rather than dropping in unannounced on you. That was unprofessional of me, but I was drunk. I'm sorry if I made you feel awkward or anything. Especially when I used your PC without asking. Drunk Rachel can be a dick."

The way she was talking was different. This wasn't the usual Rachel, despite her *trying to be*. Something was wrong, I could just feel it. *Fuck it*. I needed answers.

"Hey, funny thing," I said, turning away to leave, then turning back with a frown. "You said your phone was dead but I looked out of the window after you left and saw you use it."

Her brows knitted together, her expression turning thoughtful. "I... don't remember. Maybe I got it to turn on briefly. It's not been holding charge well recently—I think it died again after I left. Honestly, Paul, I was drunk. Everything's a bit of a blur."

The words felt rehearsed, too smooth. My instincts bristled as I studied her, but her tone left no room for an argument.

“Right,” I said, keeping my tone even as I forced myself to accept the excuse.

She leaned slightly closer over her desk, her voice dropping to something more private, the faintest trace of warmth creeping back into her expression. “Listen, Paul... about last night. I’m not lying when I say everything is blurry, but I do remember... what we did — almost did. At your place. In the shower... You know what I’m talking about. Just keep it between us, please? I was drunk and horny and... No one needs to know, okay?”

Her eyes locked onto mine, the undertone in her voice unmistakable.

“Of course,” I replied.

Rachel’s smile widened slightly, her composure returning as if the awkwardness had been smoothed over like a wrinkle in her blouse. “Thanks. I appreciate you being discreet.”

I nodded but said nothing else, the sense of unease slipping away slightly. Maybe she was telling the truth. Perhaps her phone came on with that last little bit of juice then died once she was out of sight. Maybe she just felt awkward and left because I’d rejected sex with her, not once but twice.

I left her to get on with her work and searched for Marcus, finding him hunched over his screen with the telltale furrow of intense focus etched across his brow. His coffee cup sat untouched beside him, its contents likely cold by now. I approached cautiously, unsure if this conversation would be any different from the wall of lies I’d hit yesterday.

“Marcus,” I said, keeping my tone neutral. He didn’t look up, but I saw his fingers pause over the keys.

“Paul,” he said after a moment, leaning back in his chair and swivelling to face me. His smile was tight, forced — the kind you wore when someone interrupted you mid-thought. “What’s up?”

I stepped closer, lowering my voice. “Are you sure the bug you were working on is fixed? You didn’t seem to want to talk to me about it yesterday.”

Marcus rubbed the back of his neck, his expression shifting into something sheepish. “Yeah, sorry about that.” He gestured vaguely at his screen. “But everything’s fine, Paul. No need to worry.”

“Fine?” I repeated, my voice edging higher. “You were freaking out about it not that long ago. Then you stopped answering calls, went radio silent,

and now you're telling me it's fine?"

Marcus sighed, leaning forward and resting his elbows on his desk. "Look, I got into my own head about it, and I shouldn't have. But it's taken care of now. The bug's gone. I re-coded the entire module, and it works great."

The certainty in his voice unsettled me. It was like he'd flipped a switch — gone from wary and evasive to confident and dismissive in a matter of hours. "This might sound weird, Marcus, but has someone said something to you? Someone from Elysium, maybe?"

"Huh?" Marcus took off his glasses and stared at me for a moment. "No. I explained to you. I got it wrong. It was just a couple of lines of rogue code. Now it's gone. The software's back on track. It'll be ready to ship soon. We're just waiting on the final data interface module for the updated sensor framework, but that's out of our hands now. The hardware guys are finishing that up. Victoria Nash and James Wilson are thrilled. You need to stop worrying. Seriously. We did it."

I stared at him, searching for any crack in his composure, any flicker of uncertainty. There wasn't one. He looked me straight in the eye, steadfast and calm in a way that should've reassured me. Instead, it left me feeling like I was the one overreacting.

"Alright," I said with a heavy sigh. "Good work, I guess."

Marcus's smile returned, though it looked more tired than pleased. "Thanks. Now, if you don't mind, I should get back to it. This thing isn't going to beta test itself."

I nodded and turned away, heading back to my desk, though my mind was far from settled. The pleasant chatter of the office buzzed around me as I logged into my terminal, half-expecting to find something amiss. But there was nothing. Marcus had been right — the bug was gone. All the code modules were surrounded by green borders. Connected. Working as they should.

I spent the rest of the day throwing myself into work, answering emails and security-signing the last few blocks of code, trying to convince myself that things were finally under control. Marcus seemed fine. The software was fine. Even Rachel, with all her oddness, had seemed more... normal today. Maybe I'd been overthinking everything. Maybe my paranoia was getting the better of me.

The office emptied slowly, the usual exodus of coworkers shuffling toward their cars and trains as the day wound down. I stayed at my desk longer than I needed to, finishing off renaming the hotel management software, externally and internally, to its new name, RoomRecall. By the time I finally packed up, the sunlight outside had softened into early evening, casting long shadows across the ground as I left.

As I crossed the parking lot, my jacket slung over one shoulder, I immediately noticed Rachel near my car, next to a man I couldn't identify — a tall, athletic figure with dark sunglasses and a cap pulled low enough to cast a shadow across his features. They were facing each other, talking in low voices, but I couldn't make out the words. The tension in my chest returned as I slowed my pace, watching them.

They continued talking until the man glanced in my direction as I got close, the sunlight glinting from his sunglasses before he turned and walked away. His movements were deliberate but quick, disappearing into the row of cars. I cursed. I hadn't gotten close enough to see his face properly.

"Paul!" Rachel said brightly as I got to my car, her tone light, almost chipper. The unease I'd felt just moments ago clashed with her cheerful expression. "Sorry if this looks weird. That was just my boyfriend."

"Boyfriend?" I echoed, keeping my tone neutral. "The one you thought was going to hit you last night?"

Rachel nodded, brushing a strand of crimson hair behind her ear and giving me a small, wry smile. "Yeah, I think I overreacted last night. Sure, we've had some ups and downs, but we talked, and I think it'll work out. Hopefully."

I didn't know what to say to that. "Well... I hope it does. Anyway, is there a reason you're here, waiting by my car?"

"Thanks, I hope so too," she replied, her smile widening slightly. "I was waiting for you. I just wanted to thank you again for last night. You were kind to me, and I appreciate it. But please don't tell anyone, okay? My boyfriend and I are trying to figure things out, and I wouldn't want anyone to get the wrong idea about you and me."

Her words were deliberate, carefully chosen, and her eyes stayed locked on mine, as if daring me to disagree. She seemed so fine, so composed, that

the last bit of tension that was in my shoulders began to ease. Maybe I really had been overthinking everything. I'd always had Rachel down as this precise, professional woman, but maybe... maybe she was just a normal person caught up in her own messy life like everyone else.

"Of course," I said finally, giving her a small nod. "I get it."

"Thanks, Paul," she said warmly, stepping back and gesturing toward her car. "I should go. He's waiting for me. Have a good night."

"You too," I replied automatically, finding myself watching her curvy hips as she sauntered away towards her car. For a moment, I allowed myself to recall what she looked like naked. Her soft, pale skin. The freckles on her tits. The hint of red hair between her thighs.

I shook myself, pushing away the thoughts and sliding into my car, exhaling deeply and letting the beeps of NOVA's startup sequence greet me. "Destination, Paul?" the AI prompted in its smooth voice.

"The Nest," I said firmly, trying to stop thinking about Rachel so that I could focus on what I needed to tell Adam and Nadia.

"Understood," NOVA replied just as smoothly, though something in the way it responded sounded... different. I dismissed it as my mind playing tricks on me from the stress, leaning back in the seat as the car pulled out of the lot.

The roads melted into a blur around me as NOVA guided me away from TechSphere, the soft purr of the engine and faint chimes of traffic signals filling the quiet. But as we drove, I realized the route was unfamiliar — this wasn't the route we'd taken to Nadia's Brooklyn base last time.

I frowned, glancing at the dashboard. "NOVA, is this the correct way?" I asked, my voice cutting through the quiet.

"Yes. We are en route to The Nest," the AI replied, its tone just as smooth as before. "Estimated arrival, eighteen minutes."

I stared at the screen. "But this is a different route to before." I couldn't pinpoint why, but something about this felt off.

"Last time, we were taking evasive measures," the AI replied. "It's good to take different routes to ensure we aren't being tracked."

My phone buzzed, distracting me from my thoughts about where we were. I glanced at the screen and felt a warm fuzziness in my chest when I saw Sam's name. I picked it up without hesitation, pressing the phone to my ear. "Hi, Sam. I'm so glad you called."

“Hey, Paul,” she said, her voice soft but guarded. “I got your message... I wanted to call sooner, but...” She trailed off, and I could hear the hesitation in her pause.

“I’m just happy to hear your voice,” I said quickly. The relief in my tone was genuine, but it didn’t stop a guilty knot from forming in my stomach. “I wanted to explain. To apologise. About... everything.”

“You gave me a chance to explain, so I guess I owe you the same. Go on,” Sam said, her tone cautious, like she wasn’t sure she wanted to hear whatever I had to say. “I’m listening.”

I took a deep breath, my grip on the wheel tightening. “Look, I’m not proud of what I did. After I saw you with Raoul, I... I wasn’t thinking straight. I was hurt, angry... I wasn’t myself. So I went out, to O’Malley’s.” The words stuck in my throat, but I forced them out. “I met someone there. I don’t even know her name. It was stupid. It was just a one-off thing. It didn’t mean anything. If I’d known you and I were going to work things out... if I’d known what you told me about Raoul, it wouldn’t have happened, I promise.”

The silence on the other end of the line was deafening. I could picture Sam’s face, her lips pressed tightly together, her eyes narrowing in the way they did when she was trying not to betray her emotions. “So you did sleep with someone,” she said finally, her voice flat.

“Yes,” I admitted. “I did. And I feel terrible about it. It was a knee-jerk reaction, a stupid mistake. I guess in some twisted way, I wanted to feel like I was evening the score. But it didn’t change anything. It didn’t fix anything. If anything, it just made me feel worse.”

“Paul...” Sam’s voice softened slightly, but the edge of hurt was still there. “Why didn’t you tell me? Not just about the girl from O’Malley’s. About your ex-wife.”

“I don’t know,” I said honestly. “I don’t have a good excuse. I fucked up, I guess. Same reason you didn’t tell me about Raoul. Maybe.... we’re as bad as each other.”

Sam let out a soft sigh. “Maybe we are,” she said quietly. “But I don’t think that means we can’t try to be better.”

I nodded, even though she couldn’t see me. “I want to see you,” I said, the words coming out before I could second-guess them. “Come over tomorrow. Let’s talk. Properly talk. Clear the air.”

Sam hesitated, and I could hear the conflict in the way she breathed. “I don’t know, Paul. Things are... messy between us. Perhaps too messy, And I don’t know if I’m ready to just pretend that none of this happened.”

“I’m not asking you to pretend,” I said quickly, my voice firm but not harsh. “I just want to talk. To try to fix this, if we can.”

Another pause, then a soft, “Okay. Tomorrow. But don’t get your hopes up, okay?”

“I won’t,” I promised even though I felt a surge of optimism run through me. “Thanks, Sam.”

The call ended, and I dropped the phone onto the passenger seat, exhaling slowly, feeling less guilty and more relieved. Relieved that Sam had agreed to see me again. Relieved that, maybe, we could start to untangle the mess we’d made of things.

Shortly afterward, The Nest loomed ahead — Nadia’s Brooklyn hideout. The wind had picked up sharply since I left the office, and the faded ‘No Trespassing’ sign rattled against the graffiti-covered door as I pressed the button on the rusted intercom.

No one answered. I recalled Adam scanning his hand on the device instead of pushing the button and tried pressing my palm against it but still, nothing. I looked around, wondering how I was supposed to get in and spotted a small, black camera swivel down, moving to point at me.

“It’s me,” I said, looking over my shoulder to make sure no one was around. “Paul Lacuna.”

A small LED flickered to life below the lens, and a scanner beam swept over my face as I waited, but no voice came through the camera or the intercom. Then, after what felt like an age, the door finally buzzed open, the mechanical groan echoing into the cavernous dark inside.

I remembered the way, following the corridor, the air smelling of rust and ozone like last time, but something didn’t feel right. The overhead lights flickered, casting jagged shadows across empty workbenches strewn with half-assembled tech — circuit boards, neural chips, and tangles of copper wire. My footsteps echoed too loudly as I crept further in.

Then as the corridor opened up into the main room where I’d first met Nadia, I saw it: a pool of dark, viscous liquid glistening beneath a flickering yellowing bulb. Blood. Fresh enough to still gleam. My breath hitched, the metallic tang sharp in the air.

“Adam?” I called out, my voice swallowed by the emptiness. “Nadia?”

The sound of boots on concrete snapped my head to the right. The man from the hotel stood there, the man who'd brought me room service then pursued me from D.C. He wore the same cap as the man I'd seen Rachel talking to earlier. The sunglasses were folded, hanging from his collar. Two other men flanked him, dressed in black tactical gear, their faces obscured by masks.

"Don't run," the man from the hotel said flatly, raising a sleek, matte-black pistol. He must have seen my muscles tense because he shook his head slowly. "Paul, don't run."

I ran.

A gunshot rang out, something pinging off metal as I ducked behind a workstation, my heart pounding against my ribs. Adam was right. I was in danger, more than I'd realised. Something made from glass shattered somewhere to my left, raining shards through the air as I turned to run back down the corridor the way I'd come, but one of the masked men stepped in front of me. I skidded to a stop, my feet sliding on the polished concrete floor and bolted in the opposite direction, through a door, a bullet whistling past my head. Too close.

I ran deeper into The Nest, barely able to see where I was putting my feet in the flickering blue ceiling lights. The men shouted behind me, other voices garbled through comms devices.

A fire exit glowed red ahead. I slammed into the bar on the door, bursting into a narrow alley choked with smoke from a nearby dumpster fire. Brooklyn's skyline loomed above, the lights from glowing windows blurred in the smoky haze. I sprinted left, then right, no idea where I was running to, my lungs burning as I wove through graffiti-painted back streets cluttered with trash.

Footsteps echoed close behind, but I daren't look over my shoulder. I vaulted over a chain-link fence, tearing my jacket on some barbed wire that topped it, then stumbled into an alley behind a windowless warehouse-type building. I kept running and then slammed my feet into the dirt, sliding to a stop. I was in a dead end — brick walls on three sides, only trash cans for company.

"Fuck!"

I spun, searching for an escape. A rusted ladder bolted to the wall was my only chance. I climbed, my palms scraping raw against the rough steel, and

hauled myself onto the roof just as the first man, the guy from the hotel, rounded the corner.

I sprinted across the roof of the warehouse until I hit a gap between roofs, the city roaring below. It was what? Six feet? I could clear it. I looked behind me, seeing my pursuer clear the ladder, finding his feet on the roof. I took three steps back, then ran forward, leaping as far as I could manage, feeling my heart freeze in my chest until I felt the roof of the neighbouring building beneath my feet.

I ran across the next rooftop, hearing sirens wailing somewhere nearby, but I didn't stop until my legs gave out. I slid down another ladder and collapsed behind an HVAC unit in a dimly lit alley, the cold brick biting into my back as I gasped for air.

"Paul."

A woman's voice. Soft. Urgent.

I jerked upright, pressing into the shadows behind the HVAC, out of sight and then peered carefully around the corner. Rachel stepped into the alley's mouth, her face pale under the streetlight.

"Paul, listen," she whispered, her eyes darting around her, looking for me. "I know you're here somewhere. They're still looking for you. I can get you out of here, but we have to move *now*."

I stayed put, retreating further into the shadows, but her footsteps approached and a moment later, she stepped around the corner, gazing at me, holding her hands above her head.

"We don't have time, Paul. You need to come with me now. Now."

"Why should I trust you?" I said, rising to my feet, poised on the balls of my feet, ready for whatever might come next. "I saw you with the guy who's chasing me."

Her gaze locked onto mine, unflinching. "Because I'm risking my life to save yours. He was asking questions. Threatened me. I didn't know what to do. Please, just come with me now, before they catch up and get both of us."

Something in her tone — a crack in her armour — made me hesitate. But against every instinct, I nodded.

We slipped through a nearby alley, down a side street, the voices of the men that had chased me somewhere behind us, further away than before. She paused at a large steel-plated doorway that swung open beneath a broken neon sign. "In here," she said, her voice trembling.

I hesitated, then headed through the door as she waited outside, her eyes keeping check on the quiet street outside. The room inside was large but empty. A temporary hiding place. She followed me inside a moment later, pulling the door closed behind her.

“Rachel — “ I began, as she stepped close, her face barely visible in the darkness. “What’s going on?”

“I’m sorry,” she whispered.

The needle in her hand pierced my neck before I could react. Something fiery-hot flooded my veins.

“Sleep now,” she murmured, catching me as my knees buckled.

The world tilted. Her face blurred above me, shadows swallowing the edges of my vision. The steel doors opened, and the three men walked in, looking down at me as Rachel lay me down flat on the floor.

Then nothing.

Cold bit into my wrists first — the sharp, sterile kind, metallic and unyielding. My eyelids fluttered open to a ceiling of clinical white panels humming with white spotlights. The air smelled of antiseptic and something acrid, like burnt circuits. I tried to move, but restraints held my arms and ankles firm against a reclined surgical chair. Panic surged, my heartbeat pulsing in my throat as I tried to work out where I was.

To my left, Adam strained against identical bonds, his face swollen and streaked with dried blood. His eyes met mine briefly — a flicker of grim recognition — before he turned his head away, jaw clenched.

“He’s awake,” a familiar voice purred.

Rachel stood at the foot of my chair, her red hair now pinned neatly under a surgical cap, her slender frame draped in a tailored white lab coat. She adjusted a console beside her, her movements precise, almost ritualistic. Behind her, the man from the hotel loomed over Adam’s chair, his angular face split by a grin that revealed too-white teeth.

“Let him go!” I shouted, my voice raw. “Let us both go. What the fuck is going on?”

The man turned slowly, his pale eyes glinting. “Ah, Paul. Still playing the hero? How predictable.” He stepped toward me, his booted footsteps loud

against the polished tiled floor. “You *do* remember me, don’t you? I’m sure I see a flicker of recognition in your eyes.”

“You were at the hotel,” I nodded grimly. “You brought my room service, then followed me back to New York.”

“Not from the hotel,” he laughed. “You know me, Paul. From long before that.”

I stared, my pulse roaring in my ears.

“No?” He leaned closer, his breath reeking of mint. “I fucked your wife, Paul. Many, *many* times. She was such a good fuck. Fantastic tits. Tight pussy. Ah, I miss the lovely Claire.” He lingered on her name, savouring it. “I came on her pretty face so many fucking times. Don’t you remember? You should. You loved watching. At least, the old Paul did. The times you were there, at least.”

Rage flared white-hot in my chest. I jerked against the restraints, the metal cuffs biting into flesh. “You’re lying — ”

“Am I? Don’t you remember anything at all? We became friends. You got me the job at Elysium, Paul. We fucked Claire together. Let me prove it to you.” He pulled a phone from his pocket, swiping to a photo — Claire, naked and laughing beneath him on a hotel bed. The same bed from the journal entries. My stomach lurched. He swiped again. Another photo, this time there was a cock in her mouth. His cock, I presumed. He swiped again.

“Enough,” Rachel interrupted, her tone cool as she inserted a vial into a pneumatic injector. “We’re not here to indulge your theatrics, Jean-Marc.”

He scoffed but stepped back, sliding the phone back into his pocket before I could see the next photograph.

I twisted toward Rachel, desperation clawing up my throat. “Who are you, really? Why are you doing this?”

“I’m Rachel,” she shrugged. She didn’t look up. “I’m doing this because it’s what you chose, Paul. The *original* you. The one who couldn’t live with what he’d done. With what he’d become.” Her gloved fingers tightened around the injector. “You wanted out, and you knew this was the only way. Okay, we might have tweaked a few things from the contract you signed, but it was working. Until you started prying... and well, here we are.”

“He might have chosen to forget Claire,” Adam snarled, rattling his restraints. “But he’d never choose this. The safe word sequence exists for a reason — the right to reversal.”

Rachel ignored him, her gaze settling on me. “Did you think we wouldn’t notice Nadia’s AI overwriting NOVA? My father built Elysium’s systems with her. He knows all her tricks, as does my mother. Tracing her pathetic hack took minutes.” She tilted her head, a brittle sympathy in her eyes. “We actually thought she was dead. That the reprogramming had fatal consequences. She did well to hide from us all this time, but you led us right to her. So... thank you.”

“You didn’t get Nadia,” Adam growled. “I saw her get away. If you’d caught her, she’d be here, instead of me. You know I’m of no use to you.”

“Shut up,” Jean-Marc, the man from Claire’s journals, warned him, raising a fist, causing Adam to flinch and go silent.

“You’re wrong,” Rachel informed him, without turning away from me for a moment. “You’re not useless. We might not have been able to capture Nadia, but with you here, she’ll come to us. And when she does...”

Adam screamed in fury, testing his restraints, struggling against the bonds, but they held firm.

Rachel stepped closer, the injector poised above my forearm. “When we reset your memories before, I came with you to TechSphere. I’ve looked after you this whole time. So you have to trust me. This is for the best.”

“No. Please,” I begged her. “Stop. We can talk about this.”

But she ignored me. I felt the prick of the needle against my skin.

“This will only hurt for a moment.”

“No — wait!” I had one hope. A Hail Mary. “*Secret. Etch, Chore. Reach* — ”

Jean-Marc’s hand clamped over my mouth before I could finish, the fourth word stifled. Rachel froze, her composure slipping for a heartbeat.

“Clever boy,” she murmured, caressing the injector, whatever she injected making my muscles turn to jelly. “But incomplete.”

As she spoke, the room flickered — *not the room*. A memory: fluorescents, surgical lamps. Rachel, a few years younger, her hair loose as she leaned over me in a different chair. “*Relax, Paul,*” she said, her voice gentler. “*The implant will fix everything. I promise. I’ll be here when you wake up.*”

“*I’ll see you on the other side,*” I heard myself say.

The flashback evaporated as Jean-Marc tore his hand away. I gasped, the truth, new memories, old but new, crashing over me.

“*You... You installed the chip,*” I rasped. “*You’re their surgeon.*”

Rachel's lips thinned. "And you're out of time."

She nodded to Jean-Marc, who lifted some sort of headset from a table nearby and brought it to my chair — a sleek, silver device lined with electrodes. Like one of the NeuroLink Crowns that Elysium sold as part of their SkinDeep technology. Similar but more complex and more advanced. My pulse spiked as he lowered it onto my head, the metal icy against my temples.

"This time, we're upgrading the firmware," Rachel said, fingers dancing across her console next to her before the visor slid down, obscuring my vision. "A full reset, just like your friend Harry. He's already been... *adjusted*. Just like him, you'll wake up happier. *Lighter*. Unburdened by your past."

"Rachel, *don't* — "

The NeuroLink Crown hummed to life.

And then I *remembered*.

Claire's laughter echoing through our old apartment in D.C. Harry pouring drinks, Annmarie's hand sliding up my thigh under the table.

The four of us tangled, naked in the bed sheets, covered in sweat. The smell of sex in the air.

Harry lying on his back, Claire straddling him. My hand reaching out, taking hold of his cock, guiding it into my wife's pussy.

Annmarie beneath me in a hotel room. "I love you," she whispered in my ear as we fucked.

Sitting around the desk at Elysium, Harry and Claire at either side of me, Rachel and Eleanor opposite us. The deal we'd made — to forget, to start over — on paper, a contract.

Annmarie and Claire together on the bed, their heads between the other's legs, licking each other's pussies.

"I won't be a part of this," I screamed at Harry. "This isn't what was supposed to happen."

The look on Claire's face when she realized the price and changed her mind, too late, strapped into the chair.

"Wait!" I choked out, suddenly seeing her face properly for the first time.

Seeing *everyone's* faces.

"Claire — why didn't anyone tell me? She was... And Annmarie. What the fuck? Please stop, Rachel," I implored her, the truth hitting home hard.

I'd been blind, Stupid. What had I done?

“Rachel, I don’t want this. I never got the chance to say goodbye.”

The visor slid up, the bright white light of the room blinding me for a second. Rachel stood in front of me, gazing into my eyes, her finger hovering over a button, lit up green on the console. For a moment, I saw something in her eyes — a flicker of regret. Then it vanished.

“Goodbye, Paul,” she whispered. “It’s time for a fresh start. You remember coming up with that name, don’t you?”

The headset began buzzing. I felt the Hard Core chip in my brain, a vibration, like something connecting inside my skull.

Rachel’s finger pressed the button. The visor slid back down.

“I’ll see you on the other side,” her voice promised.

Then the world dissolved into static.

Chapter Eight

Epilogue

Daylight flooded through the gap in the bedroom curtains when I opened my eyes, the scent of freshly brewed coffee and bacon drawing me from sleep. I stretched, enjoying the warmth of our bed for a moment longer before sitting up. The apartment was quiet save for the gentle clatter of dishes in the kitchen.

“Rachel?” I called out, my voice still rough with sleep.

“Just making breakfast,” she answered, her tone light and musical. “You slept like the dead last night.”

I wandered into our kitchen, pausing in the doorway at the sight of her. Rachel stood at the stove, wearing nothing but my oversized Columbia University t-shirt, her long legs bare and her flame-red hair tumbling loose around her shoulders. The morning light caught the subtle curves of her body beneath the thin fabric, her nipples pressing against the cotton as she turned to face me.

“Morning, baby,” she smiled, eyes warm as she flipped a pancake, the smell wafting over to me, making my stomach grumble like I hadn’t eaten in days. “Coffee’s ready.”

I moved behind her, wrapping my arms around her waist and pressing a kiss to her neck. “You’re spoiling me.”

“It’s a special occasion,” she murmured, leaning back against me. “It’s been exactly three years since we moved here from D.C. Three years since you proposed on our first day in our new house. Took you long enough.”

I smiled, brushing my thumb over the diamond engagement ring on her finger. The memories felt warm and clear — the spontaneous proposal at the harbour, watching the sunset paint the sky as she said yes. Buying the ring together a week later. Committing to each other, planning our future.

“Maybe we should finally set a date,” I suggested, reaching for a mug and pouring coffee.

Rachel turned in my arms, her eyes brightening. “Really? You’re ready?”

“More than ready,” I assured her. “Fall wedding? The changing leaves, the colours, it’s our favourite season. It’d be perfect.”

She beamed, setting a plate of pancakes and bacon on the table before sliding onto my lap, her bare legs against mine. “October,” she decided, fingers threading through my hair. “Let’s do it.”

I gazed past her to the window, where the skyline stretched against the morning sky. “We made the right choice coming here,” I said. “We had options, but here...”

“This is perfect,” she finished, following my gaze. “Our perfect little corner of the world.”

“Life is good,” I agreed, drawing her closer.

She traced my jawline with gentle fingers, her expression softening. “Well, if we’re going to finally tie the knot,” she murmured, “I think we should honour the occasion properly after breakfast.”

“Or before,” I suggested, my hand sliding up her thigh. She wasn’t wearing panties. I felt her pussy, hot against my fingers and I found her clit, teasing her.

Her laugh was soft against my lips as she kissed me, slow and deliberate. When she pulled back, her eyes held mine with an intensity that made my breath catch. She reached down, took hold of my stiffening cock.

“I love you, Paul,” she said, her voice dropping to a whisper. “No matter what happens, remember that.”

Before I could question the strange words, she kissed me again, slid her pussy onto my cock, taking me inside her and any thoughts I had scattered like leaves in the wind.

This was right. This was real. Rachel — the girl I’d dated since college. The only woman I’d ever slept with. The only woman I’d ever loved. The life we’d built together, here in Boston since leaving D.C.

I’d never been happier.

Afterword

Thank you for joining me on this second stage of Paul's journey through the treacherous landscape of erased memories, hidden desires, and corporate conspiracy. Your willingness to explore these complex characters and their intertwined relationships means everything to me.

"Hard Core" has peeled back several layers of mystery, but as Paul discovered in those final moments before Rachel's betrayal, answers often lead to even more questions. Who was Paul Lacuna before Elysium altered his memories? What drove him and Harry to erase their shared past with Claire and Annmarie? And perhaps most importantly—what truly happened between the four of them that was so unbearable they chose to forget?

The critical questions remain: Is Claire still alive, and if so, where is she hiding? Paul seemed to recognise her, right before his 'firmware upgrade.' How deeply has Elysium infiltrated Paul's life, and what is their ultimate goal with RoomRecall? The truth about Jean-Marc's relationship with Claire—and Paul's apparent endorsement of it, until their apparent falling out—suggests a past far more complicated than simple infidelity.

The safe word sequence that Harry remembered in fragments may be the key to everything. But as Adam and Nadia warned, using them incorrectly could cause irreparable damage. Freedom and truth often come at a steep price, and Paul will have to decide if recovering his past is worth risking his future.

As Paul now lives in a fabricated reality with Rachel in Boston, his true memories locked away once more along with all memories of his move to

New York with Harry, of Beth and Sam, the stage is set for an even more dangerous awakening. In the final installment of the trilogy, "Safe Word" (coming April 2025), Paul will face his most difficult challenge yet—recovering not just his memories, but facing the truth about who he was... and perhaps, still is.

Thank you again for reading. Paul's journey is far from over, and I hope you'll join him for the final chapter.

Until next time, as always, stay horny!

Paul

Also by Paul Garland

The Elysium Files Series

[Cheat Codes](#)

[Hard Core](#)

Safe Word (coming soon)

I Know Who You Did Last Summer Series

[I Know Who You Did Last Summer, Book 1](#)

[I Know Who You Did Last Summer, Book 2](#)

[I Know Who You Did Last Summer, Book 3](#)

[I Know Who You Did Last Summer, Book 4](#)

The My Wife... Series:

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[I Explored My Wife's Fantasies... And Found A New Kind Of Love, \(Book 5\)](#)

[I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex, Book 1](#)

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About The Author

Paul Garland is an author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night. He lives with his wife and two children in a small house in the suburbs of Sheffield, England along with a lazy green budgerigar, an African Grey parrot that curses and a tubby tabby cat which would love to eat either. (Preferably the vulgar-tongued parrot.)

He has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his *Cerulean Erotica Presents* series and *No Angels* series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began '*The Cuckold Collection*,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: *The No Angels Stories*, *The Sexy Season Stories* and *The Cerulean Archives*. 2022 began two series, *Holiday Hotwives* and *A Size Queen Story* and 2023 introduced a new series, *Improper Investigations* and the return to the *Cerulean Archives* with *I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex*. 2024 saw the *My Wife* series and the *I Know Who You Did Last Summer* series reach huge success and 2025 brings the return of the Detective Hotwife, a new series of sci-fi hotpast erotica and the climax of the *Holiday Hotwives* books.

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